



EDITORIAL

AI's new compact

Page 6

SATURDAY INTERVIEW

'Goa pitches sustainable growth'

Page 7



WORLD

Trump warns Iran of 'very hard' hit over Israel flight crash attempt

Page 9

SPORTS

Asian Games Day 13: Six golds push India to No 5 as tally rises to 76

Page 12



'Gyanu, it's done, bro' chants Shivaji Park at CJP protest



STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai, 2 October

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijit Dipke stated here on Friday evening addressing a massive rally attended by thousands at Shivaji Park, that the Central government is so incompetent, that protests are being held again after two months.

Mr Dipke sharply criticised Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and also dared Maharashtra Chief Minister to arrest the youth. Mr Dipke asked those gathered at Shivaji Park if they were willing to go to jail, to which the crowd chanted "We are willing to go to jail".

Other slogans and chants which were heard at the event repeatedly are, "Gyanu, It's Done Bro" and "Go Gyanu, go".

The event was well attended by several celebrities including actor Naseeruddin Shah, actress Shabana Azmi and musician Vishal Dadlani, who spoke at the event, besides Tushar Gandhi, the grandson of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi, who also spoke a few words. Noted documentary filmmaker Anand Patwardhan was on the stage, filming the event with a camera. Actress Sherlyn Chopra attended the event and said that she supports the Gen-Z-led movement, since everybody has the right to vote.

Another surprise speaker at the event was a 15-year-old Delhi girl Anushka, who faced severe backlash after she allegedly used abusive language against PM Modi, during the student protest at Jantar Mantar in July 2026, after which she was forced to apologise.

A smiling Anushka spoke

at the Shivaji Park event after Mr Dipke gave her the microphone. "Our government is in shock and panic. Just like when we switch on the lights, the cockroaches scatter, our government itself has become like these cockroaches," the 15-year-old said.

Speaking at the event, Abhijit Dipke said: "Devendra Fadnavis, what did you say? You said those who are going to protest, think about it, because they will have to be in jail for three days. Are you listening, Mister Devendra Fadnavis? Did you think that we would come running to you in fear like your MLAs do?"

"Your chair is patched up with sticky tape and Fevicol. Sir, you seem to have forgotten that this is Maharashtra, the land of Jijabai (Shivaji's mother), Savitribai Phule, Shahu Maharaj and Dr Ambedkar. But we have not forgotten. In Maharashtra, children are not threatened. Fadnavis, even if you jail us for three months, we will come out and come back here again and again," Mr Dipke said.

Targeting Delhi DCP Sachin Sharma, Mr Dipke said: "Sachin Sharma is the favourite General Dyer of Amit Shah. Even the Mumbai police told me this. He lifted our colleagues protesting in Delhi today. But I wish to tell them that their barricades will prove to be useless because so many people will come from all over the country. Sachin Sharma himself will fall at Amit Shah's feet to ask for a transfer. The Mumbai police told me that Sachin Sharma is an RSS member. Sachin Sharma, if you are a Sanghi, then wear khaki shorts and attend an RSS shakha. Don't wear the police uniform."

PM shares 'unforgettable' conversation with hero pilot

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday described his interaction with Flydubai Captain Smit Machchhar as an "unforgettable conversation" filled with "pride and emotions", after speaking to the Indian pilot who was seriously injured while helping avert a major mid-air tragedy.

"An unforgettable conversation with Captain Smit, filled with pride and emotions," Mr Modi said in a post on social media platform X, sharing visuals of his conversation with Machchhar, who is recovering in a hospital in the UAE.

During the interaction, Capt. Machchhar recounted the terrifying moments aboard Flydubai flight FZ1073, which was travelling from Dubai to Tel Aviv on Wednesday when he was allegedly attacked by his co-pilot. Despite suffering



serious injuries, Capt. Machchhar managed to unlock the cockpit door, allowing other crew and passengers to enter and overpower his attacker, thereby preventing a potentially catastrophic incident.

Speaking to Mr Modi, Capt. Machchhar said his 17 years of flying experience, including 11 years as a captain, helped him understand that the aircraft was descending dangerously even as he lay injured on the cockpit floor. He said he realised that he had to make one final effort to reach the cockpit door

because he could not allow the passengers to lose their lives.

Capt. Machchhar also told the Prime Minister that he had kept reciting the Hanuman Chalisa during the ordeal, saying it gave him courage in the face of fear and danger. He became emotional during the conversation and told Mr Modi that speaking to him was a "very special moment" and that he had never imagined he would get the opportunity to speak to the Prime Minister.

Mr Modi praised the pilot's courage, composure and

Today, the entire nation can proudly say that we Indians are not people who take lives ~ we are people who save lives."

NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

presence of mind, saying that Capt. Machchhar had made crucial decisions in a matter of seconds while putting the safety of others ahead of his own. "Today, the entire nation can proudly say that we Indians are not people who take lives ~ we are people who save lives," Mr Modi told him.

The Prime Minister also assured Capt. Machchhar of his support, telling him, "Whenever you need me, I am just a phone call away," and said that India was waiting to welcome him back.

Gujarat's and Assam's uniform civil code laws get President's assent



THE PRESIDENT HAS GIVEN ASSENT TO THE UNIFORM CIVIL CODE, ASSAM, 2026 ALSO ON 29 SEPTEMBER 2026. THIS EXPEDITES THE PROCESS OF THE ENACTMENT OF UNIFORM CIVIL CODES IN THE COUNTRY, BEGINNING WITH UTTARAKHAND WHICH HAS ALREADY IMPLEMENTED THE LAW.

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Gujarat's Uniform Civil Code (UCC) Bill has received the President's assent on 17 September, 2026. Following this, the State government has issued a gazette notification to initiate the process of implementation of the law.

The President has given assent to the Uniform Civil Code, Assam, 2026 also on 29 September 2026. This expedites the process of the enactment of uniform civil codes in the country, beginning with Uttarakhand which has already implemented the law.

The Gujarat UCC includes several new rules, from marriage registration to monogamy and live-in relationships. Sons and daughters will have equal property rights. In the event of an intestate death, the rights of spouses, children, and parents have been defined.

Children born through surrogacy and adoption will also have equal legal rights. The implementation of the law will mean people will have to follow the rules under it in many matters relating to family and personal law.

The law shall not apply to the members of Scheduled Tribes and those whose customary rights are protected under Part XXI of the Constitution of India.

The Statement of Objects and Reasons of the Bill said that in pursuance of the constitutional mandate enshrined under Article 44 of the Directive Principles of State Policy, which calls upon the State to endeavour to

secure for its citizens a Uniform Civil Code throughout the territory, the Government of Gujarat had constituted a committee under the chairmanship of Justice (R.) Ranjana Prakash Desai, to assess the need for implementing Uniform Civil Code in Gujarat.

The Bill sought to give effect to the committee's recommendations by providing a uniform legal framework governing civil matters for all citizens of the State, irrespective of religion, caste, creed, or gender.

The Assam Uniform Civil Code Bill, meanwhile, was passed by the Assam Legislative Assembly in May 2026, making Assam the first North-eastern state and the third in India to adopt UCC legislation.

Among other provisions, the Assam bill standardises the legal marriage age at 21 for men and 18 for women, and requires compulsory registration of all marriages and divorces within 60 days.

It completely bans polygamy and bigamy, carrying penalties of up to seven years in prison under relevant legal provisions.

It also mandates the registration of live-in relationships within one month, granting legal recognition and child legitimacy rights. It also introduces gender-equal intestate inheritance and succession rules.

Like the Gujarat legislation, the Assam UCC completely exempts Scheduled Tribes (STs) across the state from its provisions to protect their customary practices, traditions, and rituals.



Sweet Triumph

Indian players celebrate with their coach Sjoerd Marijne after their victory over China in the women's hockey gold medal match at the Asian Games, in Gifu, Japan on Friday. JANS

ECI orders special drive to enrol left-out, first-time and young voters after SIR

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

The Election Commission of India has directed Chief Electoral Officers, District Election Officers and Electoral Registration Officers in States and Union Territories where the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls has been completed to launch a special drive for enrolling eligible voters who were left out of the rolls, including young and first-time electors.

In a letter dated 1 October, the Commission said the exercise would be undertaken under the process of continuous updation of electoral rolls and would seek to identify persons whose names appeared in the pre-SIR electoral rolls but were not included in the current

rolls, besides facilitating the enrolment of new and young voters. The directive followed a meeting with all Chief Electoral Officers on 1 October.

The ECI had earlier said that SIR had been completed in 20 states and Union Territories, including Bihar and West Bengal, and that persons whose names were left out during or after the revision, as well as young and first-time voters, could apply for inclusion through the continuous updation process.

Under the latest instructions, Booth Level Officers will compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR roll and prepare booth-wise lists of electors whose names appeared earlier but are missing from the current roll. The BLOs have been asked to undertake house-to-house visits to ascertain the present

status of such persons and facilitate their enrolment through Form 6 wherever they are found eligible. The Commission has asked BLOs to cover at least 20 to 25 such electors every week so that the exercise can be completed in about a month. The status of each identified elector will be recorded, including whether a Form 6 application has been submitted.

The BLOs have also been directed to use their house-to-house visits to identify and facilitate the enrolment of any left-out, first-time or young eligible voter. The lists prepared by the BLOs will be shared with Booth Level Agents of recognised political parties, while the Electoral Registration Officers will receive the lists along with Form 6 applications and field verification reports.

India-US talks on trade deal in final stage, but no immediate agreement: USTR

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

The India-US negotiations on a trade deal have entered the final stretch, but a deal is not expected immediately as both sides continue to work through a limited number of unresolved issues, US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer (photo) said.

Speaking after the G20 Trade Ministers' Meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin, Mr Greer said negotiators had narrowed down the areas of disagreement and were working towards resolving the remaining sticking points. He described the talks as being close to the



end, while cautioning against expectations of an imminent agreement.

Mr Greer also indicated that US President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi could speak again soon to take stock of the negotiations and assess the progress made by their teams.

The latest comments come days after Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal described the proposed trade agreement as being "almost done and dusted". Mr Goyal had also said that India was seeking a competitive tariff position compared with other exporting nations before the

agreement could be finalised.

Mr Greer and Mr Goyal met on the sidelines of the G20 trade ministers' gathering in Milwaukee, with discussions focused on moving towards an early conclusion of an interim trade agreement under the broader India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement framework.

Mr Greer described their discussion as constructive and said officials from both countries were continuing negotiations. Mr Goyal said the meeting was productive adding that the discussions were aimed at reaching a mutually beneficial interim agreement.

The Commerce Ministry said Mr Goyal also held bilateral meetings with trade counterparts from other countries during his visit to Milwaukee for the two-day G20 ministerial meeting.

The latest developments follow a phone conversation between Mr Modi and Mr Trump on 30 September, during which the two leaders reviewed a range of bilateral issues, including trade, defence, energy and critical technologies.

According to the Prime Minister's Office, the leaders agreed to remain in close contact and continue efforts to strengthen the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership.

Fadnavis slams 'Fake Narrative' over Election Commission protest

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Mumbai, 02 October

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday criticised the protest being organised against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, saying that the "fake narrative" being pushed by the protesters had already been exposed.

The protest was called by Abhijit Deepke of the Cockroach Janta Party at Shivaji Park in Mumbai. Opposition groups have extended support to the agitation, while Left parties and the Aam Aadmi Party have also announced protests against Kumar in Delhi.

The developments have intensified the political campaign against the Election Commission.

Reacting to the agitation, Fadnavis said the narrative



being propagated against the Election Commission had lost its credibility after the three election commissioners addressed a press conference.

"I want to say clearly that the truth has already been exposed. After all three commissioners held a press conference, the balloon of their

fake narrative has burst. Despite this, they are trying to push the same narrative. However, they will not succeed in their fake narrative," Fadnavis said.

Meanwhile, Fadnavis visited the Dharavi redevelopment project to review its progress. Speaking before the visit, he said the project would provide

people with a real-time understanding of the existing situation in Dharavi and how the area would be transformed under the redevelopment plan.

"Real-time information about the project is available here. One can understand Dharavi's history and its present condition, including how people live today," he said.

Fadnavis said Dharavi, despite being known as a slum, is also an important economic centre with a wide range of small-scale industries.

"Dharavi has a major economic ecosystem. There are pottery units in Kumbharwada, plastic industries, food businesses and leather-related activities. A large economy operates in this area," he said.

He added that the exhibition would provide an overview of

how these economic activities and the lives of residents would be accommodated in the redeveloped Dharavi.

People will be able to see the proposed layout and understand how their lives will change, how they can run businesses from better premises and what facilities, including hospitals and religious places, will be available," Fadnavis said.

The Chief Minister also said sample homes that would be provided to eligible residents would be displayed, allowing people to understand what the redevelopment project would offer.

"This initiative will provide answers to what exactly is going to happen under the Dharavi redevelopment project. I welcome this initiative," Fadnavis said. UNI SP SAS

CJP stages massive showdown at Shivaji Park, demands CEC Gyanesh Kumar's resignation

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Mumbai, 02 October

In a high-stakes escalation of political tension, the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), led by founder Abhijeet Dipke, has launched a fierce agitation at Mumbai's historic Shivaji Park. Demanding the immediate resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, protesters accused the poll panel of gross incompetence and systematic disenfranchisement.

The demonstration, buzzing with high-octane energy, transformed the iconic grounds into a sea of dissent. Protesters hoisted sharp satirical memes, tricolours, and massive banners bearing slogans like "Save Democracy" and "Gaddaar Gyaanu Must Go" The CJP



has lambasted the Election Commission, claiming that recent electoral rolls stripped millions of citizens of their voting rights. Organizers termed the leadership "inefficient, dishonest, and a betrayal of the democratic framework."

The agitation drew notable cultural heavyweights. Acclaimed actress Shabana Azmi, singer Vishal Dadlani (who electrified the crowd with a live performance), and filmmaker

Vishal Bhardwaj marked their presence to back the movement. Setting a distinct tone, participants donned T-shirts bearing Mahatma Gandhi's portrait. Founder Abhijeet Dipke anchored his speech around constitutional values, stating, "Gandhi is the soul of this nation, Ambedkar is its spine, and Nehru is its intellect." Issuing a stern warning to the administration, CJP leaders declared that the Mumbai gathering was merely a trailer. The movement now sets its sights on New Delhi for a final showdown at Jantar Mantar.

With tensions simmering and political heavyweights weighing in, the agitation marks a critical flashpoint over the autonomy and transparency of India's electoral institution.

BRIEFLY

Minister Bawankule takes initiative to facilitate construction of medical college 8 hospital in Nashik

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Nashik, 02 October

The Revenue Department has approved allocation of 12.71 hectares of government land for construction of Nashik's Government Medical College and Hospital.

The decision was taken through the initiative of Revenue Minister Chandrashekhar Bawankule, following the directions of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis.

The land is located at Gat No. 117 in Nashik city. Of the total 13.40 hectares available, 0.69 hectares previously allotted to the MERI (Maharashtra Engineering Research Institute) has been excluded, leaving 12.71 hectares for the proposed medical college and hospital. The state government has approved the allocation of the land free of land revenue and occupancy premium. Earlier, 14.31 hectares of land at Mhasrul had been allotted for the medical college. However, the decision was subsequently cancelled after it was discovered that the land belonged to the Forest department. Following this, a fresh proposal to allot land at Gat No. 117 was approved.

The newly allotted land can be used exclusively for the approved construction and development works of the medical college and hospital.

The government has also made it mandatory for construction work to commence within three years of taking possession of the land.

Minister Bawankule said the decision to provide the necessary land for Nashik's Government Medical College was significant for medical education.

Officials assigned responsibilities amid water scarcity concerns

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Nashik, 02 October

A special campaign was conducted on October 2, marking the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi, under the Seva Sankalp Abhiyan to review programmes in Nashik and assign responsibilities to officials.

Addressing the officials, Chief Engineer Haribhau Gite expressed concern over the growing water crisis in Maharashtra and warned that farmers could face serious challenges in the coming months due to water scarcity.

The meeting was attended by Chief Engineer Haribhau Gite of the Water Resources and Conservation Department, Superintending Engineer



Rajesh Govardhan, Superintending Engineer Jeevan Pradhikaran, and Executive Engineers Sonali Shahane and Bhagwat, among other officials.

Preparations for the upcoming Simhastha Kumbh Mela 2027 in Nashik were also reviewed during the meeting, with several activities and

arrangements already underway.

Officials were instructed to remain vigilant about the emerging water crisis and take necessary measures to address the challenges facing farmers.

They were also directed to ensure the smooth implementation of the campaign and the timely execution of preparations for the 2027 Kumbh Mela.

19 more talukas added to drought-hit list after Ministers raise concerns

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Mumbai, 02 October

The Maharashtra government has expanded the list of drought-hit talukas by adding 19 more talukas following strong demands raised by several ministers.

The government has directed officials to conduct a detailed assessment of the agricultural situation in the newly included talukas.

Officials have been instructed to undertake a 20 per cent survey of the state's five major crops in each taluka, conduct physical inspections in the affected areas and submit their reports to the government on an urgent basis.

The decision to expand the drought-hit list came after several ministers reportedly expressed dissatisfaction over the exclusion of certain talukas



from the initial list of 265 despite the prevalence of adverse agricultural conditions and inadequate rainfall.

Among the newly included areas are Mudkhed, Mukhed and Ardhapur talukas in Nanded district.

The three talukas are part of the district represented by BJP leader and former chief minister Ashok Chavan.

The revised list also includes Jivti, Brahmapuri and Ballapur

talukas in Chandrapur district. The district includes constituencies represented by BJP leader and MLA Sudhir Mungantiwar as well as Congress Legislature Party leader Vijay Wadettiwar.

Patán taluka in Satara district, represented by Tourism Minister Shambhuraj Desai, has also been brought under the expanded drought assessment.

Officials have been asked

to assess the condition of the five major crops grown in the respective talukas through field-level inspections. The exercise is expected to provide the government with updated information on crop losses and the extent of the drought-like situation before further relief measures are considered.

The inclusion of the additional 19 talukas is significant as the government had earlier faced criticism over the criteria used to identify drought-affected areas.

The latest decision indicates that the administration has opted for a fresh ground-level assessment in areas where ministers and local representatives have raised concerns about crop conditions.

Earlier, the Maharashtra government had officially declared 265 talukas as drought-affected.



protest

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke addresses a protest demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at Shivaji Park in Mumbai (IANS)

Vadodara to host first Sayajirao Gaekwad Marathi Literary Conference on Oct 25

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Mumbai, 02 October

Vadodara, the historic city closely associated with Maharaja Sayajirao Gaekwad, will host the first Sayajirao Gaekwad Marathi Literary Conference on October 25, the organisers said on Thursday.

The conference is being organised by the Akhil Bharatiya Marathi Sahitya Parishad and will mark the 200th literary conference organised by the parishad, its national president Dr Sharad Gore said.

The event will celebrate the enduring contribution of Maharaja Sayajirao Gaekwad to education, libraries, culture and the promotion of Marathi language and literature, the organisers said.

During his reign, Sayajirao Gaekwad played a significant



role in promoting education and literary activities and extended patronage to Marathi language and writers. The conference seeks to highlight this legacy and provide a platform for Marathi-speaking people, writers and literary

enthusiasts in Gujarat.

Ranjanadevi Bhoite, vice-president of the parishad's Gujarat region, has been appointed president of the reception committee, while Manasi Mhaske, regional general secretary of the parishad, will serve as the convener of the conference. The literary gathering will commence with a traditional book-worship ceremony and Granth Dindi, followed by the inaugural session, panel discussions on a range of literary and contemporary issues and a poetry conference. The organisers said the event would help strengthen the cultural and literary ties between Maharashtra and Gujarat. A large number of writers, poets, literary personalities and readers from both states are expected to participate in the conference.

Guardian Minister Mahajan directs to urgently submit proposal to declare 5 more talukas drought-hit

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Nashik, 02 October

Maharashtra Water Resources and Nashik District Guardian Minister Girish Mahajan has directed officials to urgently submit a proposal to the state government seeking inclusion of five more talukas—Chandwad, Trimbakeshwar, Niphad, Dindori and Nashik—in the list of drought-affected areas.

He issued the directions while reviewing the drought situation at the District Collectorate on Thursday afternoon. He also instructed officials to prepare a comprehensive water management plan extending until August 2027.

MLA Prof. Devyani Pharande, Trimbakeshwar Municipal

Council President Triveni Tungar, District Collector Ayush Prasad, Zilla Parishad Chief Executive Officer Omkar Pawar and senior officials from various departments attended the meeting.

Mahajan said rainfall had declined this year due to the impact of El Niño, making it necessary to use available water resources judiciously. Although dams in the district currently have adequate water storage, officials must plan its utilisation carefully to ensure availability until August 2027.

He stressed that planning should cover not only drinking water requirements but also fodder and water for livestock. Farmers should be encouraged to cultivate fodder crops to

address the anticipated shortage.

District Collector Ayush Prasad informed the meeting that crop damage assessments were underway in view of the drought. Water is being supplied through nine tankers in Yeola taluka and seven tankers in Nandgaon taluka. Various measures are also being implemented to promote fodder cultivation.

The meeting also reviewed the land acquisition process for the Nashik Ring Road. Acquisition has been completed in 20 villages, and Rs 1,023 crore has been disbursed through direct purchase, officials informed the meeting.

Approximately 96 hectares of land have been acquired through direct purchase, while



government land is being utilised for the remaining

requirements. Mahajan also reviewed several

proposed and ongoing development initiatives, including the planned blackbuck safari at Mamdapur in Yeola taluka, the Trimbakeshwar tourism circuit covering Dugarwadi and Pahine, and the development of Nandur Madhmeshwar Bird Sanctuary.

The meeting also discussed the construction of a statue and museum dedicated to Sir M. Visvesvaraya on an island in Ozarkhed Dam using tourism development funds, the establishment of a memorial for martyrs in Malegaon, promotion of sericulture and increased use of drone technology in agriculture.

Reviewing projects under the District Annual Plan, Mahajan directed officials to ensure

quality standards in all development works. He called for strengthening healthcare and educational facilities and expanding sports infrastructure for athletes. He also reviewed the ongoing work at Abhinav Bharat Mandir.

He emphasised that tourism development must preserve the natural beauty of destinations while prioritising visitor safety and providing essential amenities and infrastructure in harmony with the surrounding environment. He further called for development plans that promote wildlife and nature conservation, create employment opportunities for local youth and help reduce human-wildlife conflict. With preparations underway for the upcoming

Simhastha Kumbh Mela, Mahajan reviewed various development works in Trimbakeshwar. The ceremonial flag-hoisting programme is scheduled for October 31.

He assessed preparations and arrangements at the helipad, Kushavart Kund, Purohit Sangh premises, Godavari Kund and the Trimbakeshwar temple complex.

During the meeting, Mahajan also held discussions with representatives of the tribal students' organisation regarding problems faced by ashram schools.

The meeting emphasised ensuring that students in these institutions receive essential facilities and that their basic needs are adequately addressed.

Maha MLA alleges Maoist plot in CJP protest



STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Mumbai, 2 October

BJP MLA Parinay Fuke (*photo*) alleged here on Friday that Naxalites and leftist organisations who escaped the anti-Maoist action by security forces are active behind the protest organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demanding Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar's resignation to create a Bangladesh-like chaos and overthrow the government.

Speaking to the media here on Friday, Fuke said the movement is not peaceful but an attempt to create an anti-national atmosphere. Without providing an evidence to support his claim, he said: "The Central and state intelligence agencies are investigating the entire matter thoroughly. The government will take strict legal action at the right time."

He said innocent youth of the country should not risk their education and careers by participating in such protests.

Questioning the source of finance of the CJP protest, the BJP MLA said: "Initially, the CJP pretended to be fighting for student issues. Now, their hidden political agenda has come out which indicates that the CJP is getting foreign funds to destabilise the country."

Attacking CJP founder Abhijit Dipke who called for a *Jail Bharo* protest if CEC Gyanesh Kumar did not resign, the MLA accused Dipke of trying to create a Bangladesh-like crisis in India.

Oppn leaders join CEC protest, 600 detained near Jantar Mantar

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Leaders of Opposition parties and their student wings among hundreds of protesters took to the streets here on Friday demanding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation while police detained around 600 people near Jantar Mantar and nearby places.

Workers from AAP, left parties, NSUI and AISA protested at Jantar Mantar, supporting the demand for Kumar's resignation due to alleged irregularities during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which included allegations of mass voter name deletions.

Among those detained were AAP's Atishi, Saurabh Bharadwaj, Sanjay Singh, Sanjeev Jha, activist Yogendra Yadav and several others. They were released later.

A coalition of student outfits called for the protest to mark Gandhi Jayanti.

Meanwhile, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called for a demonstration in Mumbai on the occasion.

AAP leader Atishi took to social media to share that the fervor of the revolutionaries remains intact at the Fatehpur Beri police station, stating that the fight for democracy will continue until Gyanesh Kumar resigns.

Protesters were barred from moving towards Jantar Mantar because they lacked permission for the protest, as prohibitory orders were in force across the New Delhi District under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

Security was enhanced across the New Delhi District with barricades placed on roads leading to Jantar Mantar.

Delhi Metro also closed entry and exit at 12 stations



including Rajiv Chowk, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat and Mandi House till further notice.

The DMRC withheld entry and exit at the metro stations including Janpath, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat, Rajiv Chowk, Seva Teerth, Mandi

House, Lok Kalyan Marg, INA, Chawri Bazar, New Delhi, and RK Ashram Marg had been witheld during the day by the DMRC, although interchange facility was available at Rajiv Chowk, Mandi House, INA, New Delhi and Central Secretariat stations.



Poll Row

INDIA bloc leaders stage a protest against Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar, demanding his resignation over alleged irregularities in the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and alleged mass deletion of voters in Patna, Bihar, on Friday. *IANS*

Mahagathbandhan rift widens ahead of Bihar MLC polls, RJD, Congress face off in four seats

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Patna, 2 October

The rift within the Mahagathbandhan has resurfaced ahead of the Bihar MLC elections for eight seats, with the RJD and Congress set to face each other in a friendly contest on four seats.

The Congress has released its list of candidates for five MLC seats. Four of the seats are those for which the RJD had already announced its candidates.

According to the Congress list, the party has renominated

former Bihar Pradesh Congress Committee President and sitting MLC Dr Madan Mohan Jha from the Darbhanga Teachers' constituency. The RJD has not fielded a candidate from this seat. Jha will face JD-U's Ghanshyam Rai and Jan Suraj Party's SP Rai.

The four seats where the Congress and RJD will be engaged in a friendly contest are Patna Teachers, Patna Graduates, Kosi Graduates and Darbhanga Graduates.

The Congress has fielded Dr Sanjay Yadav from Patna Teachers, Dr Asadullah Khan

from Patna Graduates, Manoj Kumar Jaiswal from Kosi Graduates and Rajnikant Pathak from Darbhanga Graduates.

The RJD has nominated Sanjeev Kumar Singh from Patna Teachers, Dilip Kumar from Patna Graduates, Nitesh Kumar from Kosi Graduates and Anil Kumar Jha from Darbhanga Graduates.

Tension within the Opposition alliance had surfaced last month after the RJD unilaterally announced six candidates for the upcoming MLC elections for eight seats, leaving only

two seats for its alliance partners.

The announcement had led to resentment in the Congress camp. Senior party leaders had alleged that the RJD announced its candidates without consulting its alliance partners and that there had been no discussion within the Mahagathbandhan over seat-sharing.

A similar friendly contest was witnessed within the Mahagathbandhan during the 2025 Bihar Assembly elections, when opposition candidates faced each other on 11 seats.

CPI-M condemns Jantar Mantar detentions, demands CEC Gyanesh Kumar's ouster

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Friday condemned the detention of hundreds of youth and student protesters in Delhi during demonstrations demanding the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, accusing the government of curbing the democratic right to protest and calling for an immediate halt to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

In a statement issued by its Polit Bureau, the CPI-M said hundreds of young people and students associated with the Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI), the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and other organisations gathered

at Jantar Mantar despite heavy police deployment and the denial of permission for the proposed protest.

The party alleged that Delhi Police had "converted the entire city into a fortress" and detained people attempting to reach the protest site. It further alleged that protesters were manhandled and forced into police buses, with several sustaining injuries.

The CPI-M said the protest was aimed at demanding the "immediate ouster" of CEC Gyanesh Kumar, whom it accused of having been instrumental in turning the Election Commission of India into "a back office of the BJP's election work". The protest came amid a wider political confrontation over the functioning

of the Election Commission and the nationwide SIR exercise. Opposition parties and several civil society and student groups have raised concerns over the electoral-roll revision process and demanded greater transparency and accountability from the poll panel, while the Election Commission has maintained that the exercise is intended to identify and remove ineligible or duplicate entries and ensure the integrity of electoral rolls.

The CPI-M said its General Secretary MA Baby and veteran leader Brinda Karat were among those detained along with DYFI General Secretary Himagnaraj Bhattacharya, DYFI president and MP A A Rahim, SFI General Secretary Srijan Bhattacharya, SFI president

Adarsh M Saji and SFI joint secretary and former JNUSU president Aishe Ghosh.

"The fact that it took more than two hours for the police to detain all the DYFI and SFI activists itself demonstrates the stiff resistance put up by the youth," the CPI-M said.

The party also criticised the denial of permission for the gathering at Jantar Mantar, describing the venue as a designated site for protests and arguing that preventing a demonstration there amounted to an assault on constitutional freedoms. Delhi Police had denied permission for the proposed 2 October demonstration and subsequently imposed restrictions and intensified security arrangements in central Delhi.

Chhattisgarh CM remembers Gandhi, Shastri on their birth anniversaries

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai (*photo*) on Friday paid tribute to Mahatma Gandhi and former Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri on their birth anniversaries.

He said the values they lived by - truth, non-violence, simplicity and service - remain relevant to the nation.

At Chhattisgarh Sadan, Sai offered floral tributes to the two leaders and recalled their contributions to public life. Speaking about Gandhi, Sai said his unwavering faith in truth, non-violence and humanity conveyed a message of peace and harmony.

Gandhi's concern for the poorest sections of society



and his vision of a self-reliant India, he said, continue to inspire people to uphold truth and discharge their responsibilities towards the country.

Sai also remembered Lal Bahadur Shastri for his simple way of life, steadfast leadership and dedication to the nation. His call of "Jai Jawan, Jai

Kisan", he said, highlighted the contribution of soldiers and farmers to India's security and economic well-being.

The Chief Minister said the lives and ideals of Gandhi and Shastri would continue to guide the country in its pursuit of public welfare, good governance and service to the nation.

'Gandhi's life an immortal saga of dedication to truth, non-violence'

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Patna, 2 October

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Friday paid tribute to Mahatma Gandhi on his 157th birth anniversary, describing his life as an "immortal saga" of dedication to truth, non-violence and service to the nation.

Choudhary said Gandhi's thoughts had shown not only India but the entire world the path of humanity, peace and Satyagraha.

Paying homage to the Father of the Nation, the Chief Minister said Gandhi's ideals continued to inspire society and the nation.

He also shared a photo-graph of Gandhi along with his tribute message.

Choudhary also paid tribute to former Prime Minister and Bharat Ratna awardee Lal Bahadur Shastri on his birth



anniversary, saying his simple life, determination and dedication to national service would remain an inspiration for generations.

"On the birth anniversary of former Prime Minister of India and great freedom fighter, Bharat Ratna and

revered Lal Bahadur Shastri Ji, I offer my respectful tributes," Choudhary said in his message.

He said Shastri's simplicity, determination and dedication to national service would continue to inspire the people of the country.

Vande Bharat clocks 100 kmph, crosses iconic Chenab Bridge at high speed

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Jammu, 2 October

The Vande Bharat Express on Friday scripted a new speed milestone on the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL), clocking 100 kmph for the first time on the Katra-Banihal section and crossing the world's highest Chenab Rail Bridge and the cable stayed Anji bridge after the Railways raised the speed limit on this mountainous section.

Union Railways Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw shared on X a video of a Vande Bharat crossing the Chenab and Anji railway bridges at 100 km/h, the first time the train has operated at that speed over the two structures on the Jammu-Srinagar rail route.



"100 km/h over India's engineering pride!" Vaishnaw wrote on X.

The maximum permissible speed on the 111 km long Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra - Banihal section has been increased from 75 km/h to 100 km/h.

The increased speed was successfully tested today. Vande Bharat Express (Train No. 26401/26404) created a new record by crossing the world's highest Chenab Bridge and India's first cable-stayed Anji Bridge at 100 km/h, officials of the Jammu

Railway Division said.

This enhancement will make train operations on the USBRL project smoother, reduce travel time and provide faster, safer and more comfortable journeys to the passengers.

The Railway Ministry had recently granted approval to increase the maximum permissible speed of trains to 100 kmph.

Earlier, the permissible speed on this section was 85 kmph for the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra - Sangaldan section and 75 kmph for the Sangaldan - Banihal section.

The decision to increase the speed limit was taken after ensuring compliance with all the prescribed safety conditions by the Railways.

Woman murdered in broad daylight in Chhatarpur

HE CONTINUED STABBING AND THRASHING HER FOR NEARLY TWO MINUTES, BUT NONE OF THE ONLOOKERS INTERVENED TO STOP HIM OR SAVE HER.

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Bhopal, 2 October

In a gruesome incident, a young woman walking home was murdered by a man who stabbed and kicked her before finally slitting her throat with a knife in broad daylight in Chhatarpur town of Madhya Pradesh on Friday.

According to the police, the deceased has been identified as Jyoti Chaurasia. She was from Maharajpur and currently lived in a rented house in Amaltas Colony in Chhatarpur.

Locals informed the police that Jyoti worked as a waitress at a nearby hotel.

She was walking home after buying groceries from a shop when two men approached her on a motorcycle.

They stopped the motorcycle near her, and the pillion rider got off and immediately began assaulting her with a knife.

He continued stabbing and thrashing her for nearly two minutes, but none of the onlookers intervened to stop him or save her.

Meanwhile, the other accused remained seated on the motorcycle. Soon afterwards, the two men sped away, leaving Jyoti lying in a pool of blood.

People informed the police, and a police team rushed to the spot. However, Jyoti had died before the police arrived.

Chhatarpur ASP Aditya Patle said that a case had been registered and that the police were examining CCTV footage to identify and nab the assailants.

SP tests caste strategy to woo Brahmins, non-Yadav OBCs for Uttar Pradesh polls

BY MANOJ BHADRA
Lucknow, 2 October

After the success of the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, Akhilesh Yadav's new caste-based calculations may face a major test in the upcoming Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections early next year.

The Samajwadi Party will target Brahmins, non-Dalit Jatavs and non-Yadav OBCs. This new SP strategy has increased the BJP's concerns and forced the ruling party to find ways to counter the tactic.

Besides, the BJP will have to fight to protect its own vote bank in the UP Assembly elections.

According to sources in the SP, the strategy now is to break the social alliance that has helped the BJP win election after election in Uttar Pradesh.

Following the success of



its new caste equation in the Lok Sabha elections, the SP's strategy is to move beyond its image as a Muslim-Yadav party and prioritise non-Yadav OBCs, non-Jatav Dalits and Brahmin communities in ticket distribution.

If these segments prioritise caste over party, as they did in the Lok Sabha elections,

the contest will be interesting. The BJP will face the challenge of keeping its base vote bank united and breaking through the SP's maze.

On the other hand, the BJP leadership has raised an alarm over the SP's new strategy.

According to a senior BJP leader, the party's biggest challenge is to reconquer the

non-Yadav OBC and non-Jatav Dalit segments, a large portion of whom sided with the SP in the last Lok Sabha elections.

This section, which had supported the BJP in the 2014 and 2019 Lok Sabha elections and the last two Assembly elections, did not show the same old sense of allegiance to the BJP in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

Since the SP's 2024 ticket distribution formula was successful, it will not only favour the Kurmi, Nishad, Gurjar, Pal, Saini and Prajapati communities among the OBCs and the Pasi community among Dalits to deal a blow to the BJP in the Assembly elections, but will also woo Brahmins in eastern UP and Awadh. Therefore, to blunt this SP move, the BJP will have to make a major change in its strategy, a senior BJP leader suggested.

According to SP sources,

in the last Assembly election, the SP alliance distributed nearly 125 tickets to Muslim-Yadav candidates. This made it easier for the BJP to woo non-Yadav OBCs. This time, the SP plans to limit the number of tickets for Yadavs and Muslims to 80-85 seats. The plan is to field Dalit candidates in some general seats where the Muslim-Yadav-Dalit voters combine to create an unbeatable position.

Furthermore, the plan is to provide a large number of tickets to members of the Brahmin community among the upper castes, Kurmis and Nishads among the OBCs, and to give greater representation to Sainis, Gurjars, Rajbhars, Pals and Prajapatis.

In the Lok Sabha elections, the SP fielded only five candidates from the Yadav community and only four from the Muslim community.



Remembering Gandhi

Students create a human-chain rangoli depicting Mahatma Gandhi as part of the 'Swachhata Hi Seva' programme under the Seva Sankalp campaign on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti at the New Police Lines in Gauriganj, in Amethi district of Uttar Pradesh on Friday. IANS

PDA Vyapar Sabha conference in Kashi kicks off SP's preparations for UP Assembly polls

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Varanasi, 2 October

On the instructions of Samajwadi Party (SP) national president Akhilesh Yadav, the Samajwadi Vyapar Sabha, Uttar Pradesh, is organising divisional and district conferences across the state to connect traders and the Vaishya community with the party. In this regard, the PDA Business District Conference was held on Thursday at the Shri Ram PG College of Commerce and Education campus on Paigambarpur-Panchakroshi Road in Varanasi, where approximately 500 representatives from the business, Vaishya and Baniya communities participated.

SP Chandauli MP Virendra Singh and Legislative Council member from the Varanasi Graduate Constituency Ashutosh Sinha were the chief guests at the conference. Samajwadi Vyapar Sabha State President Pradeep Jaiswal and SP State Secretary Dr Ajay Chaurasia were also present as special guests. Mr Singh said the public is witnessing how the government is working across the country to promote large corporations at the expense of small shopkeepers.

He claimed that the business community is with the Samajwadi Party and Akhilesh Yadav this time.

He said he would continue to raise the concerns of businesses and traders in the Lok Sabha.

CM Yogi links 'One District-One Product' scheme ODOP with Bapu's Charkha

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow, 2 October

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, describing Mahatma Gandhi's mantra of Swadeshi and self-reliance as the foundation of a self-reliant and developed India, said Bapu's charkha was not merely an object but the foundation of India's self-reliance and self-sufficiency. Uttar Pradesh's 'One District-One Product' scheme is working towards making 'local to global' by carrying forward the same spirit of Swadeshi.

He said: "Prime Minister Narendra Modi is taking forward Bapu's dream of self-reliance with the resolve of Atmanirbhar Bharat. The vision of a developed India will be fulfilled only when

the country becomes self-reliant. For this, every citizen, family and village will have to move forward towards self-reliance". At a programme organised on the occasion of the 157th birth anniversary of Rashtrapita Mahatma Gandhi, the CM paid tribute to Bapu's memory and offered homage on behalf of the people of the state. During the programme, he listened to Bapu's favorite bhajans and spun the charkha, conveying Mahatma Gandhi's message of Swadeshi and self-reliance.

He said: "From cleanliness to Swadeshi, from Swadeshi to self-reliance and from self-reliance to Gram Swaraj, Bapu's thoughts continue to guide the country even today." New India is moving forward with complete commitment

to realise these very dreams of Bapu.

CM Yogi, while discussing Swadeshi, also shared childhood memories. He stated: "In our childhood, we used to look at the clothes from Gandhi Ashram with great curiosity. People were especially enthusiastic about these textiles because they were not merely clothes. They were also symbols of mantra of India's freedom. Bapu worked to connect them with the spirit of Swadeshi and take them forward. He conveyed the message of self-reliance to the country through the charkha. The *charkha* was not merely a means of spinning yarn. It became the foundation of India's self-reliance and self-sufficiency."

Mayawati attacks SP, says party promoting nepotism and money power in name of 'PDA'

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow, 2 October

Days after the Samajwadi Party (SP) fielded industrialist Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani in the Rajya Sabha biennial polls, Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) chief Mayawati accused the SP of practising nepotism and relying on money power, saying that while the party calls itself socialist and a PDA party, its conduct during elections is contrary to these claims.

Mayawati said in a series of posts on the social media platform 'X' on Friday that the BSP does not give tickets to big capitalists and wealthy people in any election, whether big or small, unlike opposition parties, especially

the SP, and does not rely on their financial power. She said the BSP only fields hard-working Ambedkarite candidates from among the poor, middle class and weaker sections of society. Taking aim at the SP, the BSP chief said the party does exactly the opposite while pretending to be a socialist and so-called PDA party. Referring to the SP's renomination of Professor Ram Gopal Yadav in the Rajya Sabha elections, she said he is a close relative of the SP chief. Mayawati also raised questions about the SP's second candidate, Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani, saying that he is associated with a well-known business family.

Classified

LEGAL NOTICES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING ATTENDANCE OF DEFENDANT (Order 5, Rule 20 of the Code of Civil Procedure)

IN THE COURT OF SH. HIMANSHU SEHLOTH, Civil Judge-02, Central, Room No. 354A, 3rd Floor, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi CS - 76/2025

NEENA VERMA AND ANR. VS. TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES LTD. AND ORS.

To, DEFENDANT NO. 2: TSR CONSULTANTS PVT. LTD. OFFICE AT C-101, 247 PARK, LBS MARG, VIKHROLI WEST, MUMBAI, MAHARASHTRA - 400083

THE DEFENDANTS ABOVE NAMED WHEREAS you are intentionally evading service of summons it is hereby notified that you shall not defend the case on the 06.10.2026 day fixed for the final disposal, it will be heard and determined ex-parte.

Given under my hand and the seal of the Court, this 05-09-2026.

Civil Judge-02, Central, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

Seal of the Court

COURT NOTICE
(Rule 5 Rule 20 CPC)

IN THE COURT OF Mr. Pawan Saini
Civil Judge (Junior Division), Gurgaon
HAWA SINGH
Vs.
M/S ASHTA CHEMICALS AND ORS
CNR No. HGR02-00277-2023
Next Date: 12-10-2026

PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
M/S ASHTA CHEMICALS AND ORS
THROUGHTS PROP. NEERU
KHANDELWAL 11232-33 KUMBHA
MARG PRATAP NAGAR
SANGNER JAPUR RAJASTHAN
320022

M/S ASHTA CHEMICALS THROUGH ITS PROMOTER MANAGING SH. MUKESH KHANDELWAL 40, KALYANI NAGAR, SIKAPUR ROAD, SANGNER, JAPUR, RAJASTHAN

M/S ASHTA CHEMICALS THROUGH ITS PROMOTER MANAGING SH. MUKESH KHANDELWAL 40, KALYANI NAGAR, SIKAPUR ROAD, SANGNER, JAPUR, RAJASTHAN

In above titled case, the defendant(s) respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s) respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 12-10-2026 at 10:00 a.m.

For details login to https://highcourtsd.gov.in/?mod=district_notices&cat=04

Date, this day of 24.09.2026
Civil Judge (Junior Division)
Gurgaon

IN THE HIGH COURT OF DELHI AT NEW DELHI
NOTICE UNDER ORDER V RULE 20 CODE OF CIVIL PROCEDURE
Case No. FAO 479/2018
Appel Against order dated: 26.02.2018
Passed By: Mr. Vineta Goyal, Additional District Judge-03, (South District), Saket Courts Complex, New Delhi in Case No. 4887 No. 2772017 and CNR No. DLST01-02064-2017

APPEAL EXPORT PROMOTION COUNCIL. Vs. **M/S G N B BROTHERS PRIVATE LTD.**

Notice to: Respondent
M/S GNB Brothers PVT LTD
C-185, Vikaspuri, New Delhi

Whereas the above noted appellant has presented an appeal Under Section 37 of the Arbitration and Conciliation ACT, 1996 which was listed before the Court on 17.12.2018 & the Court ordered issuance of notice to you. And whereas it has been proved to the satisfaction of the Court that you cannot be served in the ordinary manner. Notice is hereby issued that if you wish to defend the above mentioned appeal and applications you may cause an appearance to be entered on your behalf either in person or through an advocate duly appointed by you for the purpose before the Joint Registrar (Judicial) on 14.10.2026 at 11:00 A.M.

If no appearance is made on your behalf, by yourself, your pleader or someone by law authorized to act for you in the said appeal and application on the aforementioned date, no further notice of the subsequent date of hearing of the said appeal and application will be given and the same will be heard and determined ex-parte in your absence.

Given under my hand and seal of this Court, this the 09th day of September 2026.
Assistant Registrar
For Registrar General

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<https://epaper.thestatesman.com>

UP moves ahead of national average in stopping funds after cyber fraud

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow, 2 October

Uttar Pradesh is strengthening police action against cyber fraud through technology.

Under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, besides preventing cybercrime in the state, special emphasis is being laid on stopping and recovering funds after fraud.

In September, the state's rate of freezing funds involved in cyber fraud stood at 34 per cent, higher than the national average of 31 per cent. Through the Cyber Fraud Mitigation Centre, officials are freezing and recovering diverted funds through real-time routing. In several cases, recovery of up to 100 per cent has been

recorded within the stipulated time limit. The state has also conducted 84,000 cyber awareness drives to prevent cybercrime. Through these campaigns, people were made aware of phishing, fake websites, data theft, fake approvals and other methods of cyber fraud.

At various locations, from cinema halls to railway stations, people were informed about the need to exercise caution during digital transactions and check the authenticity of digital platforms.

The Cyber Fraud Mitigation Centre plays an important role in stopping funds involved in cyber fraud. As soon as a complaint is received, action is initiated through the concerned bank to stop the funds.

Through real-time routing

and data sharing, the process of freezing diverted funds and recovering them is taken forward. This helps address the challenge of funds rapidly moving into other accounts after fraud. On the directions of CM Yogi, DG Cyber Crime Vinod Kumar Singh has equipped police personnel in the state with advanced technology. Personnel are also being trained in new technologies to combat cybercrime. In view of AI deepfakes, mule accounts and changing methods of cybercrime, emphasis is being laid on enhancing the technical capabilities of the police.

SP Cyber Crime Rajesh Yadav stated that time is the most important factor in cases of cyber fraud. He said that filing a complaint within the

first hour significantly increases the possibility of getting the funds held or frozen.

He said cybercriminals target people through several methods, including phishing, fake websites, data theft and fake approvals. In such situations, it is essential to verify the authenticity of a digital platform before using it and remain alert. Under the leadership of CM Yogi, a strong system has been established in the state to deal with cybercrime. Every police station has a cyber help desk. Meanwhile, a 1930 call centre and the Cyber Fraud Mitigation Centre are being operated in Lucknow. As soon as a complaint is received, action is taken through the concerned bank to stop the funds.

Tripura court jails five Bangladeshis, imposes ₹ 30,000 fine each

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Agartala, 2 October

A local court located in South Tripura on Thursday sentenced five Bangladeshi nationals to a period of four months' simple imprisonment and imposed a penalty of Rs 30,000 upon each individual under the provisions of the Immigration and Foreigners Act.

The court pronounced Parimal Chandra Das (38), Nishi Das (36), Mrdul Das (30), Arjun Das (30), and Helendu Das (35), are guilty. All of them are domiciled in Kalyani under Dhiraipolice station jurisdiction of Sunamganj district of



Bangladeshis.

According to Tripura Police, the five individuals were apprehended by officers from PR Bari police station in Rajnagar, South Tripura district, on 14 June, following receipt of intelligence indicating that certain Bangladeshi nationals had procured a white Maruti Ertiga vehicle from Radhanagar locality through the facilitation of an Indian intermediary and were proceeding toward Agartala.

Subsequently, a police contingent established a checkpoint at Rangamura and intercepted the afore-mentioned vehicle, resulting in the arrest of the five Bangladeshi nationals.

The accused parties faced prosecution under Section 21 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act in relation to PR Bari police station Case No. 17/2026, which was registered under Sections 21/23/24 of the Immigration and Foreigners Act and Sections 183/184/187 of the Motor Vehicles Act. Following a comprehensive investigation, Sub-Inspector Bikash Debnath of PR Bari police station filed the charge sheet on 11 August.

(Representational image)

UP leads rooftop solar drive with 74,796 installations in September

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow, 2 October

Uttar Pradesh ranked first in the country in September 2026 in rooftop solar installations under the Pradhan Mantri Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana.

According to officials, 74,796 rooftop solar plants were installed in the state in September. Andhra Pradesh, with 69,813 installations, and Maharashtra, with 60,907 installations, ranked second and third, respectively.

Gujarat recorded 45,616 rooftop solar installations, while Kerala recorded 30,315.

Thus, Uttar Pradesh topped the country in monthly rooftop solar installations in September. In September,



Uttar Pradesh installed an average of 2,493 rooftop solar plants per day. On 30 September, the state recorded 3,389 installations in a single day. During the month, Uttar Pradesh recorded 29,180 more installations than Gujarat and 13,889 more than Maharashtra. A total of 438,815 rooftop solar installations were recorded nationwide in September, with Uttar

Pradesh accounting for approximately 17 per cent.

Under the leadership of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, the state is promoting the expansion of renewable energy.

The state-level implementation, inter-departmental coordination and progress monitoring of the PM Surya Ghar Yojana are being overseen by UP NEDA Director Ravinder

Singh. As of 30 September, 2026, a total of 86,775 rooftop solar installations had been completed under the PM Surya Ghar Yojana in Uttar Pradesh.

Their total installed capacity had reached 2,911.39 MW. Gujarat, with 870,152 installations, was ahead of Uttar Pradesh by just 2,397 installations, while Maharashtra's cumulative

installations stood at 827,182.

Under the free electricity scheme, eligible domestic electricity consumers can avail themselves of a subsidy for installing rooftop solar plants. The scheme is open until 31 March, 2027. Officials are urging the remaining electricity consumers in the state to apply for rooftop solar plants under the PM Surya Ghar Yojana in a timely manner and avail themselves of the subsidy as per their eligibility. Consumers can apply through the PM Surya Ghar National Portal. By adopting solar energy, electricity consumers can not only reduce their electricity bills but also contribute to the expansion of clean energy.

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, DELHI
4th FLOOR, JEEVAN TARA BUILDING, PARLIAMENT STREET, NEW DELHI-110001

OA No. 544/2025
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA VS Applicant

M/S KHANDELWAL FASHION VS Defendant

To, 1. M/S KHANDELWAL FASHION THROUGH MRS. N. KAPOOR CHAND KHANDELWAL S/O MR. THAKUR LAL KHANDELWAL
X/2596 Gali No. 7 Raghupura No. 2 Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-110031.
Also At: 9/6912 Arya Samaj Gali No. Gandhi Nagar, New Delhi-110031.

2. MRS. SAROJ KHANDELWAL W/O MR. KAPOOR CHAND KHANDELWAL
X/2596 Gali No. 7 Raghupura No. 2 Gandhi Nagar, Delhi-110031.
Also At: 9/6912 Arya Samaj Gali No. Gandhi Nagar, New Delhi-110031.

Whereas the above-named applicant has instituted a case for recovery of Rs. 65,89,834.82 (Rupees Sixty Five Lakh Eighty Nine Thousand Eight Hundred Thirty Four and Eighty Two Paise Only) against you and whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in ordinary way. Therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance before Ld. Registrar on 05.02.2027 (for further details kindly visit DRT website: www.drt.gov.in Phone Number 011-23748473).

Take notice that in case of your failure to appear on the above-mentioned day before this Tribunal, the case will be heard and decided in your absence.

(i) All concerned may attend their cases by hybrid mode (by physical appearance in the Court or through CISCO WEBEX VC Link).

(ii) For online appearance through VC all the Advocates /Litigants shall download the Cisco Webex application/software.

(iii) "Meeting ID" and "Password" for the next date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar/Recovery Officer-I and Recovery Officer-II shall be available one day prior to the next date at DRT Official Portal i.e. "drt.gov.in" under the Public Notice Head.

(iv) In any exigency qua that, the Advocates / Litigants can contact the concerned official at Ph. No. 011-23748473.

Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal on this 25th September, 2026.

SEAL OF COURT

By Order of this Tribunal

Hamirpur:
Under-construction bridge collapses, one worker dead, five injured

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Hamirpur (HP), 2 October

A major accident occurred on Friday in Hamirpur district when an under-construction bridge over the Hathli Khad (ravine) suddenly collapsed, killing one worker, while five others were seriously injured. Six workers were engaged in construction work on the bridge, situated between Cheel Vahal and Masiyana, when it fell approximately 100 feet into the ravine below.

One worker died on the spot, while five others sustained serious injuries and are currently undergoing treatment at Hamirpur Medical College.

According to reports, the bridge under construction was made of iron and was said to be over 100 meters long.

On Friday, while the workers were busy with their tasks, a section of the bridge broke off and fell.

Deshraj, an eyewitness present at the scene, stated that he was cutting grass nearby when he heard the loud sound of the bridge collapsing, followed by the screams of the workers. Local residents worked hard to help extricate the injured from the debris.

Upon receiving news of the accident, teams from the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), the district administration, and the police rushed to the site.

Hamirpur's Naib Tehsildar, Jagdish Chand, stated that approximately eight workers were present at the site when the section of the bridge collapsed.

The administration immediately intensified rescue operations and transported the injured to the hospital via ambulance.

CM Rekha Gupta participates in cleanliness drive in Azadpur to mark Gandhi Jayanti

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday participated in a cleanliness drive organised in Azadpur under the 'Seva Mera Yogdan' campaign on the occasion of Gandhi Jayanti.

Besides taking part in the cleanliness drive, the Chief Minister conducted a detailed inspection of the area and took stock of the condition of the central verge, footpaths, roadside walls, drainage system and nearby public spaces.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister sought information from officials about the garbage in the area, encroachment of footpaths by fruit vendors, unauthorised advertisements on walls and damaged public



infrastructure.

She directed officials to ensure there is no negligence in the cleanliness and maintenance

of public spaces and that the issues are addressed through permanent solutions.

Chief Minister Gupta also

inspected the central verge in the Azadpur area and reviewed the cleanliness arrangements there. She directed officials to

ensure regular cleaning of the central verge and surrounding areas.

She instructed them to improve the underpass and the long walls in the area through wall paintings and beautification, so that the area has a cleaner and more attractive appearance.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister also interacted with people selling fruit on the footpath. She said that a proper solution would be worked out keeping in mind the needs of people who depend on their businesses for their livelihood, while ensuring that the footpaths remain accessible to pedestrians and cleanliness is maintained in the area.

She asked officials and local representatives to ensure better coordination so that commuters do not face inconvenience and suitable arrangements can also

be developed for the vendors. She also appealed to fruit vendors and workers at Azadpur Mandi to help maintain cleanliness.

She said that while respecting the hard work of workers who sell fruit on carts to earn their livelihood, it is also important to ensure that no waste is left behind after work is over.

"If waste generated after selling fruit on the footpath is left there, it can enter the drains and once again affect the drainage system. Therefore, a proper cleanliness system should be ensured with the cooperation of both officials and workers engaged at the mandi," she said.

Chief Minister Gupta said that a statue of late former Prime Minister and Bharat Ratna Atal Bihari Vajpayee is planned to be installed at the chowk being developed in the

area in December, and the chowk will be named 'Atal Chowk'.

She directed officials to ensure that the chowk and the road connected to it are kept clean and made attractive. Special attention should also be given to greenery, cleanliness and better public facilities in the area, the Chief Minister stated.

The Chief Minister said Mahatma Gandhi considered cleanliness the foundation of a healthy and civilised society.

She said that the Swachh Bharat Mission, launched 12 years ago under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, has now become a nationwide people's movement. She said cleanliness should not be limited to a one-day campaign, "but should become part of our lifestyle and values".

Vande Bharat clocks 100 kmph, crosses iconic Chenab Rail Bridge at high speed

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

The Vande Bharat Express on Friday scripted a new speed milestone on the Udhampur-Srinagar-Baramulla Rail Link (USBRL), clocking 100 kmph for the first time on the Katra-Banihal section and crossing the world's highest Chenab Rail Bridge and the cable stayed Anji bridge after the Railways raised the speed limit on this mountainous section.

Union Railways Minister



Ashwini Vaishnaw shared on X a video of a Vande Bharat crossing the Chenab and Anji railway bridges at 100 km/h, the first time the train has operated at that speed over the two structures on the

Jammu-Srinagar rail route. "100 km/h over India's engineering pride", Vaishnaw wrote on X.

The maximum permissible speed on the 111 km long Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra -

Banihal section has been increased from 75 km/h to 100 km/h. The increased speed was successfully tested today. Vande Bharat Express (Train No. 26401/26404) created a new record by crossing the world's highest Chenab Bridge and India's first cable-stayed Anji Bridge at 100 km/h, officials of the Jammu Railway Division said.

This enhancement will make train operations on the USBRL project smoother, reduce travel time and provide faster, safer and more comfortable journeys

to the passengers.

The Railway Ministry had recently granted approval to increase the maximum permissible speed of trains to 100 kmph.

Earlier, the permissible speed on this section was 85 kmph for the Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Katra - Sangaldan section and 75 kmph for the Sangaldan - Banihal section.

The decision to increase the speed limit was taken after ensuring compliance with all the prescribed safety conditions by the Railways.

Haryana Police arrest fintech manager for allegedly supplying fake bank accounts to cybercriminals

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Panchkula, 2 October

Haryana Police have arrested a fintech company's district sales manager for allegedly helping create fake bank accounts and supplying them to cybercriminals, uncovering what investigators suspect was a financial channel used to facilitate online fraud in Nuh, police said on Friday.

The accused, Soyab Ali, a resident of Patakpur village in Ferozepur Jhirka, was arrested on October 1 by a team of the Nuh Cyber Crime Police Station in connection with a case under investigation. Ali was working as a district

sales manager with Spice Money Pvt Ltd, which functions as a banking correspondent for NSDL Payments Bank, according to a police spokesman.

Police alleged that Ali colluded with Rasid, a retailer from Padhaini village who has already been arrested in the case, to open fake NSDL Payments Bank accounts through a Common Service Centre (CSC) and subsequently provide them to cybercriminals.

Investigators are probing the network of accounts allegedly created through the arrangement and whether they were used to receive, transfer or withdraw proceeds of online fraud.



Floral Tribute

Delhi CM, Rekha Gupta pays tributes, to the memorial to Mahatma Gandhi on his 157th birth anniversary at Rajghat, in the capital on Friday. SUBRATA DUTTA

India's Dr. Bimal N. Patel assumes office as Judge of ITLOS

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Dr. Bimal N. Patel, an eminent international law jurist, scholar, and institution-builder of global standing, has taken oath as a Judge of the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea (ITLOS) at the Tribunal's headquarters in Hamburg, Germany.

Dr. Patel assumed this eminent international judicial office for a nine-year term commencing on 1 October 2026, marking a significant milestone in a career devoted to international law, law of the sea, ocean governance, maritime security, legal scholarship and public institution-building.

Currently the Vice Chancellor of the Rashtriya Raksha

University (RRU), Dr. Patel was elected on 18 June 2026 at the thirty-sixth Meeting of States Parties to the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) held at the United Nations Headquarters in New York. Seven members were elected to the Tribunal at the meeting.

Members of ITLOS are elected by the States Parties to UNCLOS from among persons enjoying the highest reputation for fairness and integrity and possessing recognised competence in the field of the law of the sea.

The Tribunal comprises 21 independent members, elected with due regard to equitable geographical distribution and representation of the principal legal systems of the world.

Opposition leaders among hundreds join protest against CEC, 600 detained near Jantar Mantar

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Leaders of Opposition parties and their student wings among hundreds of protestors took to the streets here on Friday demanding Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation while police detained around 600 people near Jantar Mantar and nearby places.

Workers from AAP, left parties, NSUI and AISA protested at Jantar Mantar, supporting the demand for Kumar's resignation due to alleged irregularities during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, which included allegations of mass voter name deletions. Among those detained were AAP's Atishi, Saurabh Bharadwaj, Sanjay Singh, Sanjeev Jha, activist Yogendra Yadav and several others. They were released later.

A coalition of student outfits called for the protest to mark Gandhi Jayanti.

Meanwhile, the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called for a demonstration in Mumbai on the occasion.

AAP leader Atishi took to



social media to share that the fervor of the revolutionaries remains intact at the Fatehpur Beri police station, stating that the fight for democracy will continue until Gyanesh Kumar resigns.

Protestors were barred from moving towards Jantar Mantar because they lacked permission for the protest, as prohibitory orders were in force across the New Delhi District under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS).

Security was enhanced across the New Delhi District with barricades placed on roads leading to Jantar Mantar.

Delhi Metro also closed entry and exit at 12 stations including Rajiv Chowk, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat and Mandi House till further notice.

The DMRC withheld entry and exit at the metro stations including Janpath, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat, Rajiv Chowk, Seva Teerth, Mandi House, Lok Kalyan Marg, INA, Chawri Bazar, New Delhi, and RK Ashram Marg had been withheld during the day by the DMRC, although interchange facility was available at Rajiv Chowk, Mandi House, INA, New Delhi and Central Secretariat stations.

DDA conducts safety audit of city's parks on LG's instructions, highlighting high-risk areas

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Following instructions from the Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) completed an audit of the city's parks within a week's time to address safety concerns.

The parks have been categorized for priority based interventions, officials said.

The comprehensive safety audit was done for all the 736 parks that fall under the land agency's jurisdiction and have been categorized under high (190), medium (258) and low (288), for priority-based interventions. Notably, the parks that were under high-risk category are being addressed on immediate basis.

The DDA has also identified dark spots and illumination issues, wherein 520 parks have been flagged for additional lighting provisions, while 231



parks have been taken up for immediate provision.

According to officials, works have been completed in 106 parks on immediate basis as per audit conducted in last week.

A total of 163 parks have been identified for strengthening the access issues by where unlockable gates are converted into lockable gates, while safety information boards have been

put up in 115 parks, with 484 additional signages under implementation.

As per the audit, CCTV surveillance is available across 16 parks, and now 323 additional parks have been identified for new CCTV installation.

Similarly, with regard to the boundary and vulnerable areas, repair and missing grill work has been addressed in 233 parks that had been marked

out of the 399.

In an effort to ensure better amenities and safety, areas around toilets and abandoned structures across the parks have also been flagged for corrective action as part of the exercise.

In an important step to step up the safety and security of people, night patrolling has been initiated by security guards in 245 major parks, while 134 parks have been identified as requiring armed security guards.

Bike patrolling has started in all the High-Risk parks, and a meeting had been earlier conducted with senior officials concerned, along with the security agencies to address issues.

To ensure accountability, biometric attendance has been made active in 602 parks, with implementation underway in the remaining ones.

To enhance coordination with the police, contact details

of local police/beat officers have been disseminated to field staff and vice versa along with sensitization on incident reporting and police coordination, and coverage of contact-detail distribution is 100 per cent across all parks.

SOPs are being made for patrolling, guard performance, supervisor accountability, attendance, reporting and police coordination, while the security-related tender provisions are also being updated.

Structured interaction with local Resident Welfare Associations is initiated to identify park-specific safety concerns and assign corrective actions, with meetings being conducted at Director/DD level.

Inspections by senior officers on weekly basis are being conducted, and lately senior officials have already started visiting parks and reviewing the situation.

AI’s New Compact

The White House meeting between President Donald Trump and the chiefs of America’s most powerful technology companies marks an important shift in the politics of artificial intelligence. The issue is no longer whether governments should engage with the AI industry. It is whether the world’s most consequential technology will be governed primarily by governments or by the companies building it. The distinction matters. The companies represented at the meeting ~ including OpenAI, Anthropic, Google, Meta and Nvidia ~ possess technological expertise that governments cannot easily replicate. Their cooperation is therefore indispensable. But expertise does not confer the legitimacy to determine the limits of acceptable risk.

The agreement reached at the White House points towards a model of voluntary corporate responsibility. Companies undertake to build safeguards, monitor their systems, correct failures and submit to independent auditing. Those are worthwhile commitments. Yet a safety regime becomes considerably weaker when the people developing a technology are also given substantial responsibility for defining what constitutes adequate safety. The critical question is what happens when commercial incentives collide with precaution. A company developing a highly profitable model may have reasons to deploy it rapidly, even when regulators, researchers or the public believe that further testing is necessary. Voluntary commitments can work when interests are broadly aligned. They become less reassuring when the costs of failure are borne by society while the benefits of rapid deployment accrue principally to private companies.

This is particularly significant because the technology is moving faster than conventional regulatory systems. AI can affect employment, education, journalism, intellectual property, cybersecurity and national security simultaneously. A malfunctioning financial product can cause enormous damage; an increasingly autonomous AI system could potentially create entirely different categories of risk. The answer cannot therefore be to leave every important decision to the firms with the greatest commercial stake in the technology.

The data-centre question exposes another dimension of the same problem. The AI race requires extraordinary quantities of electricity, land, water and computing infrastructure. Washington may regard this expansion as essential to American technological and geopolitical power. Communities asked to accommodate enormous facilities may see a different balance of costs and benefits. National industrial strategy cannot simply assume that local consent will follow from promises of jobs and investment.

Even Trump’s preference for calling the technology “Super Intelligence” is revealing. Terminology is never entirely innocent in politics. It can enlarge expectations, reinforce a sense of technological inevitability and make restraint appear synonymous with falling behind.

The United States is plainly determined to win the AI race. That ambition has economic and geopolitical logic. But technological leadership and effective governance are not opposites. Indeed, a country that wants its AI industry to retain public trust has an interest in establishing credible rules before a major failure forces them upon it. The meeting is an early test of whether the AI age will produce a new partnership between public authority and private power ~ or simply a new form of corporate self-governance.

Organic question

“Organic” has become one of the most attractive words in the food market. It suggests health, safety and responsible farming, and consumers in India’s cities are increasingly prepared to pay more for products carrying that promise. Yet the very success of the label raises an uncomfortable question: does the buyer actually know what is being bought?

This is not a trivial matter of consumer awareness. It goes to the credibility of an entire market. Organic agriculture is not simply a synonym for “good food”. Certification is intended to establish compliance with specified production practices. That is important because a market cannot function on claims that cannot be independently verified. The certification mark is supposed to reduce the information gap between producer and consumer. But certification can solve only part of the problem.

The consumer must also understand what the certification signifies. A shopper may reasonably associate organic food with fewer synthetic inputs, greater safety, better nutrition or environmentally responsible farming. Some of those associations may be justified in particular circumstances; others may go well beyond what certification establishes. The result is a peculiar form of information asymmetry: the producer and certifying authority may know precisely what a label guarantees, while the buyer may attach a much broader meaning to it. That creates risks on both sides.

For the consumer, the danger is paying a substantial premium on the basis of assumptions that may not be warranted. For the farmer, the danger is equally serious. Certification involves costs and compliance requirements. If consumers cannot recognise the specific value that certified production adds, there is little reason for them to pay more. The price premium that is supposed to reward the farmer for meeting higher standards then becomes difficult to sustain.

India should therefore think of organic certification not merely as a regulatory exercise but as an information system. Its effectiveness ultimately depends on whether information travels accurately from the farm, through the certification process, to the supermarket shelf and finally to the household.

This does not mean abandoning the word “organic”. Nor does it justify treating certification as meaningless. It means recognising that a technical standard and a consumer proposition are not necessarily the same thing. Food labels are, after all, promises. Their value depends on precision. If consumers need to know whether a product was produced without particular synthetic inputs, that information should be communicated plainly rather than hidden behind a single reassuring word. If organic standards encompass much more, those distinctions should be made equally clear.

The larger lesson extends beyond agriculture. In any market built on certification ~ from food and forestry to ethical sourcing and environmental claims ~ trust depends not merely on having standards, but on making their meaning intelligible. A label that consumers misunderstand may still sell products. But a certification system earns lasting credibility only when buyers know what they are paying for.

Towards Tax Certainty

One factor contributing to proliferation of tax uncertainty is pendency of matters for long before the highest court due to which the lower authorities continue to generate more cases in litigation on the same issue. One prominent example is the transfer pricing related to Advertising Marketing Promotion expenses which is pending before the highest court for years. Transfer pricing officers continue to take the same view and generate more cases for litigation

Benjamin Franklin in 1789 had famously said that nothing in this world is certain except death and taxes. Unfortunately, after 250 years, while death is still a certainty, the same cannot be said for taxes.

In his 2024 paper, “What creates tax uncertainty—evidence from 3 phases of cross country survey”, Professor Michael P. Devereux of Oxford University Centre for Business Taxation found huge variation across countries in the degree of tax uncertainty. As per the survey, 96 per cent of respondents believed tax to be very or uncertain in India.

India ranks low on tax certainty due to absence of effective mechanisms to equip taxpayers to obtain certainty upfront i.e. before commencement of transaction or at least before the tax return is filed, in order to commit oneself to a position. The next main factor is the inordinately long time taken for tax litigation to come to an end, once it starts.

The former refers to situations where a taxpayer is willing to pay his due taxes as per law but is neither sure itself nor able to get upfront clarity through an institutional mechanism. Positions based on professional advice may not be accepted by the tax department, entailing prolonged litigation along with interest, penalty and of course additional tax.

In a world of complex business transactions, especially cross-border ones, a different view by the tax authority is quite likely on issues such as existence of a permanent establishment, characterisation of nature of receipts, availability of exemptions, deductions etc. and more.

The Advance Pricing Agreement (APA) scheme launched in 2013 caters well to this requirement for transfer pricing issues. Revamp of the Safe harbour Scheme is also a welcome step in this direction. But a robust



mechanism for issues beyond transfer pricing is required. Authority for Advance Rulings (AAR) mainly constituted for cross-border transactions was closed a few years back due to administrative reasons. The Board for Advanced Rulings (BAR) which stepped into its shoes has so far not been able to function effectively.

Two aspects marring its performance are staffing on additional charge basis and the fact it comprises serving officers only. The former has resulted in the BAR disposing of few cases and the latter is not conducive for the independence of BAR. The erstwhile AAR was headed by a retired Supreme Court judge and till it functioned had a track record of issuing notable rulings.

Need of the hour is to expand the role of AAR in order to make available upfront tax certainty on a case-to-case basis, on demand. To manage the workload, a monetary threshold can be imposed. The rulings may remain binding on both revenue and tax applicants and confined to the case at hand without any precedential value.

For the second aspect i.e. long time taken in litigation once a dispute starts with the tax authority, in recent years, a number of measures have been taken to reduce number of cases under litigation such as two successful Vivadse Vishwas schemes, raising of monetary threshold for filing of further appeals by tax administration, etc.

For cross-border tax disputes, especially transfer pricing related, mutual agreement procedure mechanism under the tax treaties has been reasonably effective. India along with Japan won the OECD Tax Certainty Award twice ~ first in 2019 and then in 2025 ~ for highest resolution of transfer pricing cases.

High pendency of cases with Commissioner

Appeals has significantly contributed to tax uncertainty. Here are some suggestions. Prioritizing high demand and old appeals and full strength of Commissioner Appeals with a stable tenure of minimum two years is needed. Creation of an in-house technical

advisory cell for the Commissioner Appeals will expedite disposal due to availability of quick and well-researched positions on complex issues.

At present, disposal is stuck for years due to cases lying in the wrong jurisdiction. Immediate transfer of appeals to the jurisdictions where they belong, and faceless, international tax or central charges, will pave the way for their disposal.

The institution of Dispute Resolution Panels (DRPs) has not been able to achieve what it was supposed to.

DRP, a body of three senior officers with twenty years’ experience, viz Commissioners, is known to be predominantly taking positions favouring revenue. The well-known reason is accountability as the tax department cannot file an appeal against decisions of DRP. At present, DRP’s utility for tax payers has been reduced to a fast-track mechanism to bypass Commissioner Appeals and go straight to the Tribunal thereby saving on years in litigation.

The suggestion is not to bring back provisions to file appeals by the tax department as that would defeat the whole purpose of tax certainty. What is needed is a mechanism which infuses confidence amongst DRP members to pass orders which are fair and judicious, perhaps in terms of an assurance that they will not be questioned except in



RAJAT BANSAL

The writer is a retired IRS officer. The views expressed are personal

The Korea Herald

When headline growth tells only half the story

The Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development has sharply raised its forecast for South Korea’s economic growth this year to what would be the fastest pace in five years, citing an extraordinary boom in semiconductor exports fueled by the prolonged surge in global investment in the artificial intelligence sector.

The OECD now expects South Korea’s economy to grow 3.7 percent this year, an unusually large upward revision from the 2.6 percent it forecast just three months earlier. That would also mark the fastest expansion since 2021, when the economy grew 4.7 percent as both the country and the rest of the world began emerging from the shadow of the Covid-19 pandemic.

Despite this surprisingly strong growth outlook, domestic media reports continue

to express concerns about the vulnerability of an economy that has become excessively dependent on a single industry, semiconductors.

They point to the continuing weakness of domestic sectors outside semiconductor manufacturing and the resulting uncertainty felt by much of the population about their economic future.

Domestic service sectors are much more important than exports given their large share of employment and impact on the household balance sheets for a big number of people.

Using Bank of Korea data calculated on a four-quarter moving-average basis to identify annual trends, South Korea’s real gross domestic product grew 2.8 percent from a year earlier during the four quarters

through the second quarter. That performance was possible almost entirely because manufacturing, including the semiconductor industry, recorded a remarkable growth rate of 5.1 percent.

On the same four-quarter rolling basis, construction output fell by as much as 5.6 percent. The size of the decline is striking enough, but even more alarming is that the contraction has continued for 11 consecutive quarters.

It could be argued that higher economic growth eventually benefits everyone, even if manufacturing was virtually the only sector recording an unusually strong and potentially temporary expansion.

The government could use unexpectedly large tax revenues to repay public debt, increase public investment in productive

proven cases of perversity. This is needed to create a culture of fair and judicious orders by the DRP, which will reduce appeals to the next level by taxpayers. One factor contributing to proliferation of tax uncertainty is pendency of matters for long before the highest court due to which the lower authorities continue to generate more cases in litigation on the same issue.

One prominent example is the transfer pricing related to Advertising Marketing Promotion expenses (AMP) issue which has been pending before the highest court for years. Transfer pricing officers continue to take the same view and generate more cases for litigation. If such issues having cascading effects could be decided by the highest court on priority, it would put an end to more litigation on the same issue.

At present, there is no platform for agreement between the tax officer and the taxpayer on a disputed issue once assessment has commenced. Availability of an institutional mechanism to settle the issue raised during assessment perhaps at a level higher than the tax officer with built-in features of immunity from penalty and prosecution could nip the litigation in the bud.

It will result in a win-win situation as the tax department may realise revenue quickly and save resources on litigation, whereas the taxpayer may move on and focus on his business.

Lastly, there is a need for Circulars or Guidelines clarifying the departmental position on issues where ambiguity prevails on interpretation of legislative provision. It could be due to language or due to judicial decisions. Examples of the latter would be the department’s present position on Tax Residence Certificate and Judicial Anti Avoidance Rule versus General Anti Avoidance Rule (GAAR) after a recent decision of the highest court.

Letters To The Editor | ✉ editor@thestatesman.com

Way we teach

Sir, In his article “Re-orienting Education ~ II, published today, Dr Saumitra Mohan, IAS, explained vividly how we can create an education system that prepares students both to earn a living and to live a life of meaning. In my opinion, the way we teach must mirror the multi-dimensional nature of human life. Instead of memorising textbook facts, students should learn how to solve real-world community problems. The classroom environment must be restructured to promote collaborative projects rather than isolated run-based testing. An education system cannot support meaningful lives if it forces all students through the exact same narrow pipeline.

Policy makers must stop treating every school like a factory. Instead of prescribing rigid timetables, they should provide broad learning outcomes and give schools the autonomy to achieve them based on local realities. Teachers must accept that they are no longer the primary source of information. With AI and the internet, their role is to teach students how to filter truth from

noise, ask deep questions, and apply knowledge ethically.

Yours, etc., Deba Prasad Bhattacharya, Kolkata, 28 September.

Onus on CBI

Sir, The editorial ‘Unfinished Truth’ (September 28) incisively captures the delicate tightrope investigative agencies walk when revisiting high-profile tragedies. The Bombay High Court’s intervention in Disha Salian’s death, six years post-incident, underscores a perennial malady in criminal justice administration: procedural infirmity at the threshold.

The cardinal maxim that ‘justice should not only be done, but should manifestly and undoubtedly be seen to be done’ rests squarely upon the professional integrity of the police machinery. A prompt First Information Report, rigorous crime-scene preservation, and meticulous forensic collection form the bedrock of criminal jurisprudence.

When initial inquiries exhibit glaring procedural infirmities ~ relegating a suspicious

death to a protracted inquest under Section 174, delaying panchnamas, and omitting statutory duties ~ whether driven by institutional lassitude or executive deference, the casualty is not merely the evidentiary trail, but the credibility of the police force and public faith in the rule of law. Such administrative default invites inevitable judicial censure. The Central Bureau of Investigation must conduct an unsparing, forensic-led probe insulated from extraneous noise, establishing that justice is vindicated only through strict fidelity to due process and verifiable facts.

Yours etc., Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi, 28 September.

Price of sand

Sir, This refers to the report “Sand price capped at Rs. 1,200 per tractor in West Burdwan” (26 September). The price of sand in East and West Burdwan has touched the sky and sand smugglers in both districts have become millionaires. The administration in both districts remained silent. A number of buildings in East and West Burdwan

districts have remained incomplete because of the high price of sand. I live in East Burdwan. I could not build a fence around my house because sand was being sold at Rs 9000 per 100 cubic feet. While the West Burdwan administration has capped the price of riverbed sand, we do not know when East Burdwan will follow suit.

Yours, etc., Shyamal Thakur, Ramnagar, 26 September.

ECs must quit

Sir, Opposition parties are sharpening their attack on the Election Commission with a view to seek an SIR halt and the CEC’s ouster. At the same time I am eagerly looking for the resignation of both SS Sindhu and Vivek Joshi who objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to important decisions unilaterally taken by the CEC as alleged.

I fail to understand why they are continuing with their respective jobs when their repeated objections got overuled.

Yours, etc., Arun Gupta, Kolkata, 28 September.

SATURDAY INTERVIEW

‘Goa pitches sustainable growth’

Goa Tourism Minister Rohan Khaunte is working to position the state as a future-ready, sustainable and globally competitive tourism destination while driving greater development and improving the quality of life for its people.

An Electronics Engineer by training, Khaunte is among a rare generation of Indian ministers who combines an entrepreneurial background, three consecutive electoral victories, and responsibility for two portfolios shaping Goa's future - Tourism and Information Technology.

His approach extends beyond beaches to celebrate Goa's heritage, spirituality and village economy through initiatives such as the Ekadasha Teertha spiritual circuit, hinterland and monsoon tourism, the revival of traditional festivals, promotion of authentic Goan music and culture, and experiences that encourage visitors to engage with local communities.

In an interview with Nikhil Vyas, Khaunte spoke about the BJP's preparations for the 2027 Goa Legislative Assembly elections, Goa's tourism sector, and IT sector.

Excerpts:

Q: How are your party's preparations for the 2027 Goa Legislative Assembly elections?

A: In our party, preparation does not begin in an election year. It is part of the everyday rhythm of the organisation, working quietly and consistently at the grassroots, staying connected with people. What I can proudly speak about is the ground on which any election in Goa is contested, and that is delivery. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji, this state has received a scale of attention from the Centre that has genuinely changed what a small state can attempt - over Rs 450 crore committed across central infrastructure schemes for tourism alone, a second international airport at Mopa, Mormugao named among only six Major Ports building an international cruise terminal under the Cruise Bharat Mission, and landmark projects whose foundation

stones were laid in October 2025. The double-engine arrangement is not a slogan in Goa; it is the practical reason a state of 16 lakh people is able to plan at this scale at all.

The instruction each of us has taken from the Prime Minister and from our leadership is a simple one - that no eligible person should be left out of a scheme meant for them, in any of Goa's 12 talukas, from Pernem to Canacona. That is the work I am engaged in, and I enjoy it. And the benefits are being felt by the people.

Q: What new policies have been introduced to attract foreign tourists and promote Goa as a global tourism destination?

A: Goa is changing the way it presents itself to the world. In 2022, when I took charge, we pioneered "Goa Beyond Beaches": we are moving beyond the traditional Sun, Sand and Sea narrative and positioning the State as a year-round destination offering diverse, authentic and high-value experiences. Our objective is not simply more arrivals - it is longer stays, higher expenditure, and a wider spread of that expenditure across the State.

On the international side, our first priority is connectivity. Goa has long been one of India's leading charter destinations, and we are making charter operations more efficient, predictable and passenger-friendly while holding to the highest standards of safety and regulatory compliance. Alongside scheduled services, charters continue to bring visitors from our traditional markets in Russia, the United Kingdom and Europe, while we open newer sources in Central Asia and the CIS - Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan and beyond.

A Rs 2 crore Inbound Tour Operator Incentive Scheme has been instituted this year to incentivize charters to fly to Goa.

Some of what is required, however, lies with the Government of India, and I have placed it there. In July, I called on the Union Home Minister Amit Shah ji, and Union Minister for Tourism and Culture, Gajendra Singh Shekhawat ji, in New Delhi. Both meetings were exceptionally productive.

From the Home Ministry, the response was swift. Mr Shah approved Fast Track Immigration - Trusted Traveller Programme facilities for Goa without delay - a decision that speaks to how that Ministry has come to treat passenger facilitation as an instrument of national economic policy and not merely of security.

Mr Shekhawat has agreed to convene a joint meeting of the Ministry of Tourism and the Ministry of Civil Aviation together with the airlines - which is precisely the forum in which route restoration and the conversion of proven charter sectors into scheduled services can be settled. I am grateful to him for it, and equally to Shri Ram Mohan Naidu ji, whose Ministry has been receptive to Goa's needs.

I would add one fact that makes this a national question rather than a Goan one. Goa accounts for about 2.23 per cent of India's foreign tourist visits while accounting for roughly a third of one per cent of domestic visits. When Goa's inbound recovers, India's inbound number moves with it. That is the case I am making in Delhi, and it is being heard.

Q: How is Goa's tourism sector evolving? What challenges does it face, and what are the government's plans to expand and sustain tourism in the future?

A: Tourism is evolving globally and Goa is evolving with it. Today's traveler is looking for authenticity, sustainability, wellness, adventure, culinary culture and a real engagement with local communities. We have therefore adopted a holistic model that measures itself on the quality of the experience rather than on volume alone i.e. value over volume. Goa closed 2025 at 1.08 crore arrivals - a record, and a second successive year above a crore - and I would say candidly that the more interesting question now is not how many come, but how long they stay and where they go.

The challenges are real and I do not intend to talk around them. Carrying capacity, the pressure on land and water, cleanliness, and the fact that a very large share of our visitors still concentrate in a handful of coastal talukas - these are the things that will

determine the course of tourism. Our greatest responsibility is to see that growth stays sustainable and that local communities remain the primary beneficiaries. So, we are investing in dispersion and in depth: new circuits through the hinterland, heritage and spiritual tourism around Old Goa and the Ekadasha Teertha, the interior talukas of Sattari, Sanguem, Canacona, Quepem and Dharbandora, smart tourism infrastructure, digital visitor services, skill development and community-led enterprise.

Our Homestay Policy, the Wellness, Ayurveda and Yoga Policy notified this year with tiered accreditation, and our regenerative tourism framework - Goa is the first Indian State to formally adopt it - are all directed at the same end.

Underpinning this is central support that has genuinely changed what is possible: the projects taken up under Swadesh Darshan, the Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Digital Museum at Farmagudi and the eco-tourism project at Harvaalem among them. The Prime Minister's call of Dekho Apna Desh has been, for us, the single most powerful influence on domestic growth. Our vision is to make Goa India's benchmark for sustainable tourism, and a working demonstration of what Viksit Bharat looks like in a small State.

Q: Goa has a thriving start-up culture. How is your government supporting entrepreneurship?

A: Innovation and entrepreneurship are becoming central pillars of Goa's economic strategy. Our objective is that a talented young Goan should not have to leave the State to build something globally competitive.

The Goa Startup Policy 2025 sets us a measurable target - 1,000 startups and 10,000 jobs for Goans by 2028, with a hundred ventures enabled to access venture funding, and a dedicated mentoring and funding track for women-led enterprises. We are already close to 815 Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT)-recognised start-ups, so this is a trajectory rather than an aspiration. Through the Startup and IT Promotion Cell we have strengthened incubation,

mentoring, market access and investor connect, and we work closely with the Startup India framework and DPIIT at the Centre.

We are particularly encouraging ventures in artificial intelligence, blockchain, cybersecurity, data analytics, the Internet of Things, tourism technology, electronics and the creative industries. Beyond policy, we run conclaves, hackathons and innovation challenges through the year.

Goa offers a combination that is genuinely rare - quality of life, digital infrastructure under Goa Broad Band Network (GBBN) 2.0, two international airports, and a small enough ecosystem that government, academia and industry can actually sit at one table. Good connectivity by airways, railways, waterways and roadways. Our ambition is that Goa is counted among India's preferred destinations for start-ups and knowledge-based industry.

Q: What new initiatives have been introduced in the IT sector, and what new schemes in this sector are being planned?

A: Technology is a pillar of Goa's economic transformation. Our aim is to be among India's leading digital and innovation-driven states by combining strong infrastructure, progressive policy and responsible innovation.

We have significantly expanded digital governance, digitising services and strengthening citizen-facing platforms that improve transparency and efficiency, while promoting investment in IT, ITES, electronics and knowledge industries.

The next phase is centred on responsible artificial intelligence. AI has immense potential in governance, healthcare, education, agriculture, tourism and public service delivery. Equally, deepfakes, misinformation and cyber threats require governments to act with foresight. The Goa Artificial Intelligence Policy 2026 is at an advanced stage and will be notified soon and proposes a governance framework for ethical adoption across a three-year action plan - AI skilling from the school level upward, startup and industry promotion, investment facilitation,



governance reform and research infrastructure - with safeguards against malicious impersonation, deceptive media and other high-risk uses.

Alongside, we propose a Goa Artificial Intelligence Centre of Excellence to support research and startups in trustworthy AI, cybersecurity, deceptive-media detection and digital content authentication, providing advanced computing to innovators and academic institutions. This is deliberately framed to sit within, and draw from, the India AI Mission being taken forward by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology under Mr Ashwini Vaishnaw ji - a state of our size should build on the national mission, not duplicate it.

On resilience, we are establishing a 24x7 Goa Security Operations Centre to monitor critical digital infrastructure.

Our objective is clear. Goa should not merely adopt emerging technology - it should demonstrate, for the country, how innovation can be deployed responsibly, securely, and to the benefit of citizens.

Q: What tourism reforms have been introduced to further boost tourism in the state?

A: Tourism supports thousands of livelihoods across every taluka of this State, and my responsibility is that it keeps doing so a generation from now. Government and industry have worked hand in hand to build monsoon tourism, and today Goa is steadily moving beyond the idea of an "off-season" into a truly year-round destination. I want Goa recognised not only as India's favourite holiday destination, but as the country's benchmark for responsible, regenerative and high-value tourism.

Vape ban is losing sight of problem

SHREY MADAAN

India's vape ban was meant to keep e-cigarettes out of reach of youth. Yet recent arrests in Hyderabad show that these products are still reaching through informal channels. Four teenagers aged 15 to 17 were found using vapes, while police traced the devices to suppliers who had ordered them online and resold them. Another raid seized 53 more vapes. Seven years later, the problem is no longer whether these products are illegal. It is whether prohibition is effective enough to do its job.

The arrests are justified. Anyone selling nicotine products to minors should face legal consequences. But the raids also raise a bigger question: why does a company continue to find customers and suppliers? The Hyderabad raid offers a glimpse into how it happens. Police allege that one supplier was placing cash-on-delivery orders for several devices on websites before reselling them through an associate at a markup. These products were banned, but the demand for them had not disappeared.

That is the problem with black markets operating outside the legal frameworks. Once the market moves underground, regulators lose much of the control they would have over a legal market. There is no licensed seller responsible for checking a buyer's age, no consistent oversight of what is being sold, and no clear accountability for how products are marketed. A retailer operating legally can be penalised for selling to a minor. An illicit seller has already chosen to operate outside the ambit of law. The more the market depends on such sellers, the harder it becomes for regulators to control who gets access to these products.

The question is different with adult smokers. Vaping does not involve combustion of tobacco, avoiding many harmful substances produced through it. That's why England has adopted vaping as part of its smoke cessation programme, while Sweden has pursued harm reduction by giving adults greater access to alternatives to conventional tobacco products. The lesson is not that India should copy either model. It is that protecting young people and reducing the harm associated with

smoking does not require the same policy response.

India currently draws a much sharper line. India allows adults to purchase cigarettes through a regulated market, yet prohibits e-cigarettes altogether. An adult smoker can legally buy combustible tobacco, but cannot turn to vaping legally as an alternative. The same prohibition also leaves the vaping market outside the regulatory system that could otherwise control who sells these products, who can buy them, and how they're marketed. Hence, adult consumers seeking vapes and other safer alternatives are pushed towards riskier underground channels.

This is where regulation could offer greater control than prohibition. A regulated market would give authorities greater control over who can buy these products and how they are sold. Age checks, advertising restrictions, product standards and penalties for selling to minors could all be part of a regulated system. For adult smokers, it would also create a legal route to alternatives to combustible tobacco, rather than leaving them reliant on illicit suppliers.

Enforcement still has a crucial role to play. Black market sellers, particularly



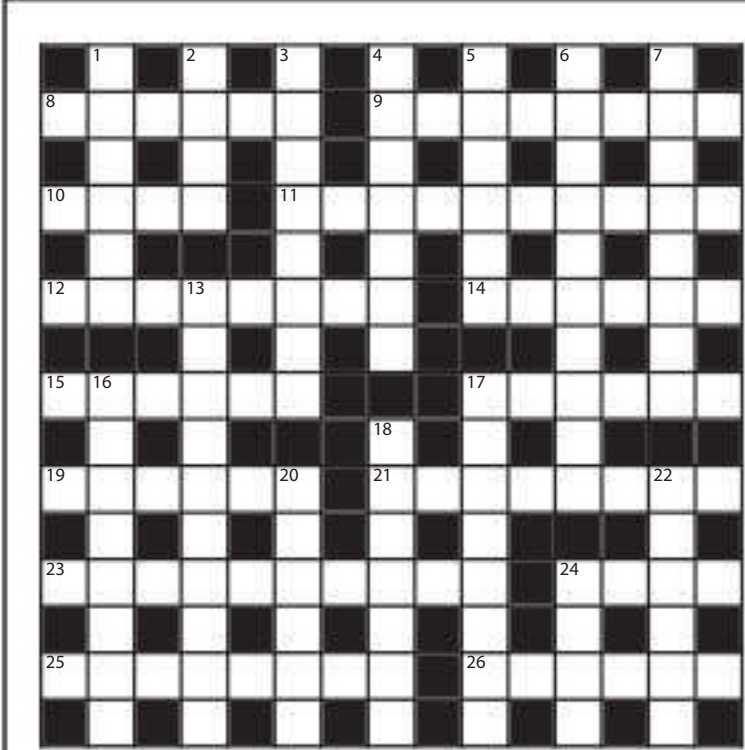
those supplying underage consumers, should be held accountable. But the policy's success cannot be measured by the number of raids or seizures. If another supplier can quickly replace the one that has been removed, the market has changed little. The focus should be on addressing the conditions that allow an underground market to thrive. India needs to distinguish between keeping nicotine away from young people and helping adult smokers reduce their reliance on combustible tobacco. The two problems are different, and policy should reflect that difference. A system designed around prohibition alone risks leaving both questions unresolved.

Indian tobacco policy should be judged by what it achieves, not by what it prohibits. If the aim is to keep e-cigarettes away from underage people, regulators need better visibility over where these products are sold and who is selling them. Leaving the entire market to illicit suppliers makes that harder. At the same time, adult smokers should not be denied access to less harmful alternatives simply because the same products can be misused by underage people. A policy that separates the two problems can protect youth without closing the door on harm reduction for adults.

Good regulation is not about making every product risk-free. It is about managing risk in a way that reflects how markets and consumers actually behave; blanket bans won't suppress the demand. India's vape ban has been in place for seven years. The latest enforcement cases suggest it may be time to look beyond seizures and ask whether a regulated, harm-reduction approach could better achieve the goal the ban was intended to serve.

The writer is Indian Policy Associate, Consumer Choice Center.

Crossword | No. 293598



YESTERDAY'S SOLUTION



ACROSS

- 8 Warm area of hard ground (6)
9 Ruling party on the left, around south, is supported uncommonly (8)
10 After joint, do giggle (4)
11 Extremely knavish career by communist playing the communist reformer (10)
12 I need to think the French paper's dropped one pair of Europeans (3,2,3)

- 14 Treated ailing ruminant in Asia (6)
15 Puts forward large packaging deal (6)
17 Province that's eight steps behind India? (6)
19 Most scheming to get agreement accepted by special officer (6)
21 Doctor cut a vein? It's not working (8)
23 Which person arrests attendant moving ecstasy in novel? (8,2)

- 24 Axes by stone portico in Greece (4)
25 Vocalist, one shouting after swallowing too many drugs (8)
26 Content to leave Zimbabwe with many a fanatic (6)

DOWN

- 1 Inflate a price to tour England's capital (6)
2 Mostly silk product from France (4)

- 3 Soviet police man breaking sticks off (8)
4 501 stars producing records (7)
5 Innovator in camp up and about (6)
6 Invalid felt sicker, having come out in most spots (10)
7 Father has something inherited with value (8)
13 Element sculpted with art in lintel (10)

- 16 Pro wrestling with medal for a prize (5,3)
17 Diddly-squat, or zero, is round number in piquet (8)
18 Fish hearts, but not hat, could be articles on boats (7)
20 Dogs are, we hear, wearing formal evening attire (6)
22 Child, under six, framing current image (6)
24 Unknown fish bones may appear in this (1-3)

NOTE: Figures in parentheses denote the number of letters in the words required. (By arrangement with The Independent, London)



BRIEFLY

T'gana Governor, CM inaugurate
Bapu Ghat Digital Museum:

Hyderabad: Telangana Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla and Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Friday inaugurated the Bapu Ghat Digital Museum at Langar Houz here on the occasion of Mahatma Gandhi's birth anniversary.

The Governor and the Chief Minister also watched a film depicting the life and message of Mahatma Gandhi at the museum.

Later, the Governor unveiled a video aimed at creating public awareness and sensitising citizens about municipal solid waste management.

Deputy Chief Minister Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka, Ministers Ponguleti Srinivas Reddy, Azharuddin and Ponnam Prabhakar, MP Vem Narender Reddy, Government Advisor V Hanumantha Rao, Government Whips Addanki Dayakar and Ramchandra Naik, Chief Secretary Sanjay Jaju, DGP C V Anand, Governor's Special Chief Secretary M Dana Kishore and senior government officials attended the programme.

SIT questions ex-Keralam Sports
Minister over aborted Messi visit

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Thiruvananthapuram, 2
October

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) of the Keralam Police, probing the multi-core financial fraud and procedural lapses surrounding the aborted visit of football legend Lionel Messi to Kerala, has questioned former Sports Minister V Abdurahiman in Malappuram.

The interrogation, which lasted several hours on Thursday, focused heavily on Abdurahiman's official foreign trips to negotiate with the Argentina Football Association (AFA), private email communications, and departmental clearances issued during his tenure.

Investigators questioned the former minister using a pre-formulated questionnaire. The SIT is scrutinising how key administrative protocols were allegedly bypassed. Abdurahiman has not been formally named as an accused in the case. In his recorded statement, he maintained that his actions were limited to fast-tracking a major government-sponsored sporting

event and denied any wrongdoing.

The investigation is looking into how *Reporter Broadcasting Company* was selected as a sponsor without a transparent tender process. Furthermore, former staff members testified that secure official ministerial channels were allegedly handled by an external aided-college teacher, despite internal warnings.

The wider case lists *Reporter TV's* Managing Editor, Anto Augustine, as the prime accused. The SIT has already submitted an interim investigation report to the Director General of Police (DGP) for further action.

The SIT is expected to cross-verify the former minister's statements with digital forensic evidence and documents seized from the Sports Department as the investigation continues.

The core of the alleged scam involves private sponsor *Reporter Broadcasting Company* (RBC), which allegedly claimed to have transferred Rs 126 crore to a foreign agency and the Argentine Football Association (AFA).

UDF 'honeymoon' over as dissent
against V D Satheesan grows



STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Thiruvananthapuram, 2
October

An internal rift has exploded in Keralam's ruling United Democratic Front (UDF). Barely four months after the Congress-led coalition assumed power under Chief Minister V D Satheesan, open conflict erupted when UDF convener and Congress MP Adoor Prakash publicly blasted the CM's functioning style.

The controversy has exposed deep factional battle lines within the Congress party and triggered intense debate among

coalition leaders.

During a packed press conference on Thursday at the KPCC headquarters, Adoor Prakash launched a direct attack on Chief Minister Satheesan's leadership style. Prakash accused the Chief Minister of running a "one-man show," bypassing the coalition's organisational structure.

Adoor Prakash stated that he frequently learns of major government actions and appointments through media reports rather than formal front-level discussions.

The UDF convener expressed strong dissatisfaction with the

lack of coordination within the UDF, noting that official front meetings have stalled because the Chief Minister, who serves as chairman, has failed to make a decision to convene them. While the convener holds the responsibility to call the state committee, doing so requires the chairman's permission. Prakash stated he should not have to constantly remind the Chief Minister of his duties, urging for a swift resolution.

He revealed that the absence of internal consultations left him unable to clearly answer media queries regarding the UDF, a situation he deeply regretted. Political observers note that Prakash's criticism is not an isolated event but reflects a larger, coordinated pushback from veteran party leaders. According to reports, a prominent section of the state unit, particularly leaders aligned with AICC General Secretary K C Venugopal, has grown increasingly resentful of Satheesan's centralised authority. Senior leaders like Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala are reportedly maintaining a tactical distance

from the Chief Minister.

Tensions are exacerbated by organisational paralysis. Several senior figures hold dual responsibilities (both ministerial portfolios and party positions), leaving little time for grassroots party management. Consequently, there are growing internal demands for the All India Congress Committee (AICC) to urgently step in and appoint a full-time Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) president to restore structural balance. The crux of the current dispute lies in a breakdown of conventional coalition management protocols. As UDF convener, Adoor Prakash's primary role is to coordinate among alliance partners. By bypassing the UDF coordination committee, which has not formally met since 30 July, 2026 - the Chief Minister has alienated key stakeholders.

The immediate catalyst for the open revolt was the unilateral Cabinet decision to award M K Muneer of the Indian Union Muslim League (IUMI) and G Devarajan of the All India Forward Bloc without consulting the front's leadership.

Vijay govt faces heat over Hindi signboards, suspends 2 engineers

UNITED NEWS OF INDIA
Chennai, 2 October

Hindi inscriptions in the signboards of Tamil Nadu State Highways department has put the ruling TVK headed by Chief Minister Vijay in the dock, with the Opposition parties including the DMK and PMK terming it as Hindi imposition, even as two engineers were suspended in this connection.

After the controversy surfaced amid allegations of Hindi imposition, the government, however in a swift move, on Friday suspended two engineers

of the Highways department after removing the Hindi names in the directional signboard, even as PWD Minister Aadhav Arjuna asserted that the TVK government would never allow three-language policy in any form and would hold aloft the long followed bilingual formula.

The new signboard, installed near the Karumeni river bridge on the Sathankulam-Nazareth in SH-93 in the southern Thoothukudi district, carried directions to Thoothukudi, Tirunelveli, Alwarthirunagari and Tiruchendur, and the

names were displayed in Tamil, Hindi and English, in that order. The presence of Hindi on the board drew public attention and triggered criticism, as most State Highways Department signboards generally carry names in Tamil and English. The issue also went viral on social media.

Following the objections, the Hindi inscriptions were removed from the signboard. Subsequently, the Highways Department's Assistant Executive Engineer and Assistant Engineer concerned with the installation were suspended.

An official release said soon

after it came to the government's attention that places names were written in Hindi along with Tamil and English, the Hindi inscriptions were removed immediately.

The Assistant Divisional Engineer and the Assistant Engineer of the Highways department were temporarily placed under suspension and departmental action was initiated for acting against the government's two-language policy. It also warned of stringent action against the government staff acting against the government's two-language formula.

PM Modi to visit Chennai on
11 Oct, launch Metro Phase 2



STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Chennai, 2 October

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Tamil Nadu on a day-long hectic tour on 11 October and participate in a series of programmes in Chennai.

According to the schedule, Modi will arrive from Delhi and launch a 14.64 km first stretch as part of Phase-2 of Chennai Metro Rail project and attend events at IIT-Madras and inaugurate a special music centre dedicated to music maestro Ilayaraja.

Seven months after getting all regulatory clearances, the first operational stretch of Chennai Metro's Phase-II expansion will be launched by the Prime Minister.

The Prime Minister is scheduled to travel by Metro Rail from Poonamallee to Porur as part of his visit along

with Chief Minister Vijay who will be sharing the dais with Modi in an event for the first time after becoming CM. The 14.64-km Poonamallee-Vadapalani corridor has been completed with 11 elevated stations.

The Chennai Metro Rail Corporation has completed the required testing and obtained the necessary approvals following an inspection by the Commissioner of Railway Safety.

The section, part of Corridor-4 or the Yellow Line, runs between Poonamallee Bypass and Vadapalani and is the first segment of the Phase II network to receive approval for commercial operations. The commissioner of Metro Railway Safety cleared the stretch for operations in February, paving the way for the launch.

The line will eventually form part of a larger east-west metro link connecting the rapidly expanding western suburbs with the rest of Chennai's public transport network. The opening is expected to provide an alternative to the increasingly congested arterial roads in the western part of the city, while also improving connectivity to existing metro services.

DMK functionary arrested in
Srirangam Temple land fraud case:

Chennai: The Crime Branch (CCB) Wing of the Tiruchi City police has arrested a functionary of the main opposition DMK, in connection with the Srirangam Sri Ranganathaswamy Temple land fraud case. The CCB police arrested DMK Srirangam Area Secretary N Ramkumar last evening near Panjapur on the Tiruchi-Madurai highway while he was proceeding to Madurai Bench of Madras High Court where he has filed an anticipatory bail plea. However, after the court dismissed his plea, he was remanded in judicial custody till 15 October. This is the third fraudulent temple land deal that has surfaced after the Palani Lord Dhandayuthapani Temple and Madurai Meenakshi Temple land rows. The land that was fraudulently registered belonged to the World famous Lord Sri Ranganathaswamy temple in Srirangam. On a complaint lodged by Temple Joint Commissioner S Sivaramkumar, cases were registered against the six people including Ramkumar on 13 September on charges of cheating and indulging in land fraud in 2022-23, besides criminal conspiracy, forgery.

Karnataka SIR: Shivakumar, Vijayendra
spar over bulk Form-7 applications

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Bengaluru, 2 October

The political battle over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Karnataka intensified on Friday, with Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and BJP state president Vijayendra Yediyurappa trading charges over alleged misuse of Form-7 applications to delete names from the voters' list.

The fresh confrontation came a day after Shivakumar, along with Cabinet colleagues, staged a dharna at the Chief Electoral Officer's office demanding action over alleged bulk filing of Form-7 applications. The CEO subsequently directed electoral officials across Karnataka to verify complaints and initiate legal action against

those found knowingly submitting false claims or objections. Vijayendra on Friday dismissed Shivakumar's protest as a "sham drama" and questioned the Chief Minister's allegation that the BJP was attempting to target minority, Dalit and Backward Class voters through Form-7 applications.

He claimed that about 24,000-25,000 Form-7 applications had been filed across constituencies, but maintained that they were not submitted exclusively by BJP workers. According to him, Congress booth-level agents, members of other political parties and social activists had also filed such applications.

Vijayendra questioned how a political party could directly

delete names from electoral rolls, pointing out that applications submitted under Form-7 have to be examined by election officials, including Booth Level Officers and Assistant Electoral Registration Officers.

He challenged Shivakumar to substantiate his allegation that the BJP was attempting to remove 5,000 to 10,000 voters from every Assembly constituency, particularly from minority, Dalit and OBC communities.

The BJP state president, meanwhile, levelled counter-allegations of irregularities in the electoral rolls, pointing to Mysuru's Narasimharaja Assembly constituency, where he claimed the number of voters had risen by about 1.30 lakh over the last two elections.

Keralam launches five-year campaign for 100 per cent waste management

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Thiruvananthapuram, 2
October

Keralam is embarking on an ambitious five-year campaign to achieve 100 per cent scientific waste management across the State and attain zero-waste status by 30 March, 2031.

The state-level inauguration of the 'Nirmalam - Puthuyuga Shuchithwa Keralam' campaign will be held at Sunny Convention Centre at North Paravur in Ernakulam, with Chief Minister V D Satheesan formally launching the programme.

The campaign, being implemented with public participation under the leadership of the Local Self-Government Department and coordinated by Suchitwa Mission, is

aimed at making Kerala a model State in waste management, Local Self-Government Minister K M Shaji has said.

The campaign will be implemented in three phases, with 30 March, 2031 set as the deadline for making Kerala a completely waste-free State.

The first phase, from 2 October, 2026 to 2 October, 2027, targets organic waste treatment facilities in 30 per cent of households and institutions and source-level treatment by 20 per cent of bulk waste

generators.

As part of this phase, 100 local bodies will be brought to full organic waste treatment capacity. Systems will be established in corporations for collecting waste from demolished buildings, while scientific treatment of 40 per cent of sanitary waste will be ensured. Construction of two new sanitary waste treatment plants will also be completed.

The second phase, from 2 October, 2027 to 5 June, 2030, will expand organic

waste treatment coverage to 70 per cent of households and

institutions and bring 500 local bodies to full organic waste treatment capacity.

Vijay launches expanded free bus travel
scheme for women, issues tickets

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Chennai, 2 October

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister launched the expanded 'Vetri Payanam' (free bus travel) scheme for women at the Koyambedu bus terminus in Chennai on Friday, coinciding with the birth anniversary of Father of the Nation Mahatma Gandhi. In line with the announcement made in the State Assembly in August, Vijay, dressed in white silk dhoti and silk full sleeves, formally launched the expansion of the scheme by issuing free travel tickets in few buses heading for various destinations. He also interacted with the women passengers, who took selfies, shook hands with them, and the elders greeted and blessed him.

The scheme is an expansion of the existing free bus travel scheme for women and was aimed at widening access to public transport, particularly for women travelling to workplaces, educational institutions, hospitals and other essential services.

Under the expanded scheme, free travel for women was extended beyond ordinary city

buses to Express, LSS and Deluxe buses operating in metropolitan and urban areas. The benefit will also cover ordinary mofussil buses and

ordinary buses operating on corporation, municipal and town panchayats and hill routes. As many as 12,695 government buses operated by the State Transport Undertakings will come under the scheme. This accounts for around 69 per cent of the 18,413 scheduled buses operated by the transport corporations. The covered services will account for a total of 1,68,500 scheduled single trips per day benefitting around 84.32 lakh women daily.

Ahead of today's launch, the government completed the integration of the scheme with electronic ticketing machines in the buses, and conducted trial runs.

**CENTRAL RAILWAY
NAGPUR DIVISION
E-TENDER NOTICE**
E- TENDER NOTICE No.
CR-NGP-M-22-OT-01.10.2026
Name of the work:- "General Furnishing, Carpentry, Plumbing and other passenger amenity work in coaches maintained at Coaching depots of Nagpur Division.", Location of the work:- Coaching Depot Nagpur and Coach Care Complex Agni and Nagpur Railway Station., Completion period:- 02 Years., Approx. cost of the work:- 3,65,60,911.60 (Rupees, Three Crores, Sixty-Five Lakh, Sixty Thousand, Nine Hundred, Eleven Rs. and Sixty Paise only), Bid Security/EMD:- ₹ 7,31,200.00 (Rupees, Seven Lakh, Thirty-One Thousand, Two Hundred only), Tender Document Cost:- Nil., Tender closing date and time:- 23.10.2026 at 12:30 Hrs., For more details, please log on to www.irops.gov.in.
Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer
Nagpur
449
Travel safely, Avoid footboard travelling

Govt. of Bihar
RURAL WORKS DEPARTMENT
Office of the Engineer-in-Chief, Rural Works Department, Bihar
5th floor, Vivekswaraya Bhawan, Nehru Path, Patna-800015
DETAILED NOTICE INVITING TENDER (through e-procurement mode only
<http://pmsgytendersbih.gov.in>)
for Construction and 06 year Routine Maintenance work (output and performance based) for Rural Road/Bridge under component of Mukhya Mantri Gram Sampark Yojana (AWSSEH).
Notice Inviting Tender (No.- RWD/MMGSY(AWSESH-SC)/HQ/ET/2026-27/02)
1. Designation and Address of the Advertiser : Engineer-in-Chief, Rural Works Department, Govt. of Bihar
2. Date of Notice Inviting Tender : 29.09.2026
3. Period for download of Tender Document : From 29.10.2026 to 11.11.2026 up to 15:00 hrs
4. Date, Time & Place of Pre-Bid meeting : Date 02.11.2026 at Concerned office of SE from 11:00 hrs
5. Last Date & Time for uploading tender documents by bidder : Date 11.11.2026 till 15:00 hrs. <http://pmsgytendersbih.gov.in>
6. Date and time of opening of Technical Bid : Date 11.11.2026 Time 15:30 hrs.
7. Details of Works and Services:

Sl. No.	Division	Block	Description of the Works [CONSTRUCTION AND MAINTENANCE OF ROADS/BRIDGE] From	To	Length (km/m)	Constructio n cost (in lakh)	Cost of Routine Maintenannc e for 72 months Period (in lakh)	Total Amount (in lakh)
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1	Hathua	Bhore	Jagdish Bantariya Nahar	Imilia Purab Tola	1.12	139.331	14.379	153.710
Total			1		1.12	139.331	14.379	153.710
2	Jagdishpur	Jagdishpur	Laxminipuri to Ayer REO Road	Esadhi Baligao REO Path	3.228	511.998	49.176	561.174
Total			1		3.228	511.998	49.176	561.174

8- Bid Validity: 180 days.
For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar
PR. No.013092(RWD) 2026-27
Engineer-in-Chief, RWD, Patna.
संपूर्ण सुख केन्द्र में आएँ, निःशुल्क एच.आई.वी. व यौन जनित रोग जाँच एवं उपचार पाएँ।

TENDER
OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL & CONTROLLER
RUHS COLLEGE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES,
Sector - 11, Kumbha Marg, Pratap Nagar, Jaipur - 302033
Ph. : 0141-2795624, 634 Email : principal@ruhscomjain.org
No. - RUHS-CMS/Store/2026-27/8211 Date - 01/10/2026
Notice Inviting e-Bids
Single Stage Two envelope Online bids (e-bids) are invited upto 02.00 pm of 08.12.2026 for Establishment and Upgradation of 1. Dept. of CTVS, Total Approx. Cost Rs. 22,50,00,000.00, 2. Dept. of Gastroenterology, Total Approx. Cost Rs. 4,55,00,000.00 on Turn Key Basis along with Medical Equipment at Existing Building of RUHS Hospital of Medical Sciences, Jaipur. Details may be seen in the Bidding Documents at the Website sppp.raj.nic.in, or eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. UBN: CMS2627GLOB00060-61
Raj.Samwad/C/26/11196
Principal & Controller
OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL & CONTROLLER
RUHS COLLEGE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES,
Sector - 11, Kumbha Marg, Pratap Nagar, Jaipur - 302033
Ph. : 0141-2795624, 634 Email : principal@ruhscomjain.org
No. - RUHS-CMS/Store/2026-27/8232 Date - 02/10/2026
Notice Inviting e-Bids
Single Stage Two envelope Online bids (e-bids) are invited upto 02.00 pm of 10-12-2026 for Establishment and Upgradation of 1. Dept. of Neurosurgery, Total Approx. Cost Rs. 31,10,00,000.00, 2. Dept. of Urology, Total Approx. Cost Rs. 9,00,00,000.00 on Turn Key Basis along with Medical Equipment at Existing Building of RUHS Hospital of Medical Sciences, Jaipur. Details may be seen in the Bidding Documents at the Website sppp.raj.nic.in, or eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. UBN: CMS2627GLOB00063-64
Raj.Samwad/C/26/11197
Principal & Controller
OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL & CONTROLLER
RUHS COLLEGE OF MEDICAL SCIENCES,
Sector - 11, Kumbha Marg, Pratap Nagar, Jaipur - 302033
Ph. : 0141-2795624, 634 Email : principal@ruhscomjain.org
No. - RUHS-CMS/Store/2026-27/8234 Date - 02/10/2026
Notice Inviting e-Bids
Single Stage Two envelope Online bids (e-bids) are invited upto 02.00 pm of 10-12-2026 for Establishment and Upgradation of Dept. of Cardiology, Total Approx. Cost Rs. 21,65,00,000.00 on Turn Key Basis along with Medical Equipment at Existing Building of RUHS Hospital of Medical Sciences, Jaipur. Details may be seen in the Bidding Documents at the Website sppp.raj.nic.in, or eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. UBN: CMS2627GLOB00065
Raj.Samwad/C/26/11198
Principal & Controller
Rajasthan State Road Development And Construction Corporation Ltd., JAIPUR.
No. SNT/2026-27/7763-82 डिटेंडर प्रमाण / 2026-27 Date:01.10.2026
निविदा के संबंधित कार्य पर समान सुविधा हेतु ई-टेंडरिंग प्रक्रिया से ऑनलाइन प्रस्ताव आमंत्रित की जाती है:- कार्य का विवरण कार्य की कीमत प्रस्तावित की जाने वाली है:-
Selection of Bidder for Collection of User Fee on the basis of competitive bidding through e-procurement basis for the
Sikar-Jhunjhunsi-Luhara BOT Road SH-08 for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00629 3671.43 Lakh 3688 / 26-27
Sikar-Julmer-Piplya-Bhawanmandi-Dug BOT Road for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00630 648.13 Lakh
Digga-Sohela BOT Road for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00631 483.21 Lakh
Pratapgarh-Manesar Road for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00632 281.84 Lakh
Udaipur-Salumber BOT Road (SH-32) for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00623 1373.11 Lakh 3688 / 26-27
Borawar-Khatu Road (SH-28) for a period of 01 Year UBN: RRC2627SL0B00624 190.33 Lakh
निविदा से संबंधित कार्य में प्रस्तावित शुल्क परीक्षण रॉडों संयोजन करने व सोलर की तापमान की जांच समुचित निवारण एवं संयोजन से संबंधित <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in>, <http://sppp.rajasthan.nic.in> तथा <http://pmd.rajasthan.gov.in/trade> पर कराना अनिवार्य है। प्रस्ताव प्रेषित की जाने वाली तिथि तक प्रस्ताव के अन्तर्गत ई-टेंडरिंग <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर प्रेषित कराना अनिवार्य है। नगरपालिका

BRIEFLY

Nepal avalanche toll rises to 15 deaths with discovery of 8 bodies on Mount Himlung:



Kathmandu: Rescuers discovered eight bodies at the base camp of Mount Himlung in Nepal on Thursday, raising the total number of deaths to 15 following an avalanche during severe weather Sunday.

The Nepal National Mountain Guide Association, which is leading the search, said rescuers dug through snow on Mount Himlung to find eight bodies in tents at the base camp, where one person remains missing.

"Due to continuing mountain hazards, recovery efforts have been temporarily concluded," the association said. "Further efforts may be possible when conditions allow."

Experienced mountain guides from the association took advantage of good weather and worked through the week to dig through the snow that covered the base camp.

Rescuers located 10 other climbers who were part of the group on Mount Himlung, a 7,126-metre (23,380-foot) peak in north-central Nepal, which is home to eight of the 14 tallest mountain peaks in the world including Mount Everest. The avalanche is considered one of the worst disasters in Nepal mountaineering history.

France school protests escalate, nearly 400 schools closed as students clash with police:

Paris: Nearly 400 schools remained closed across France on Friday as nationwide high school protests over staff shortages, overcrowded classrooms and poor school conditions intensified, with clashes between students and police reported in several cities.

Nearly 3,000 lyc  e students have been taken into police custody since the protests began, according to the Interior Ministry, including 1,949 on Thursday alone, as per local media reports.

The protests, which began in the Paris region last week, have spread across the country and increasingly turned violent. Education Minister   douard Geffray said about 400 of France's 3,700 high schools were expected to remain closed on Friday, while around 100 schools have suffered severe damage, *France 24* news reported.

In Paris, fires damaged the entrances of two high schools, while police used tear gas to disperse protesters in Brest.

Further clashes were reported in Strasbourg, Marseille, Nantes and other cities.

Trump: Iran will be hit 'very hard' if it's behind co-pilot who tried to crash flight to Israel

AGENCIES Jerusalem, 2 October

US President Donald Trump said Thursday that if Iran is linked to the copilot who tried to crash an Israel-bound flight, the Islamic Republic would be struck "very hard" for the attempt on the lives of more than 180 people aboard the jet.

Trump issued the warning as investigators worked to determine why the copilot stabbed the flight's captain, causing the FlyDubai plane to plummet before others on board stopped the attack and landed the airliner in Saudi Arabia.

The president was asked by reporters at the White House whether he had been

briefed about any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran. He said, "We're working on it right now."

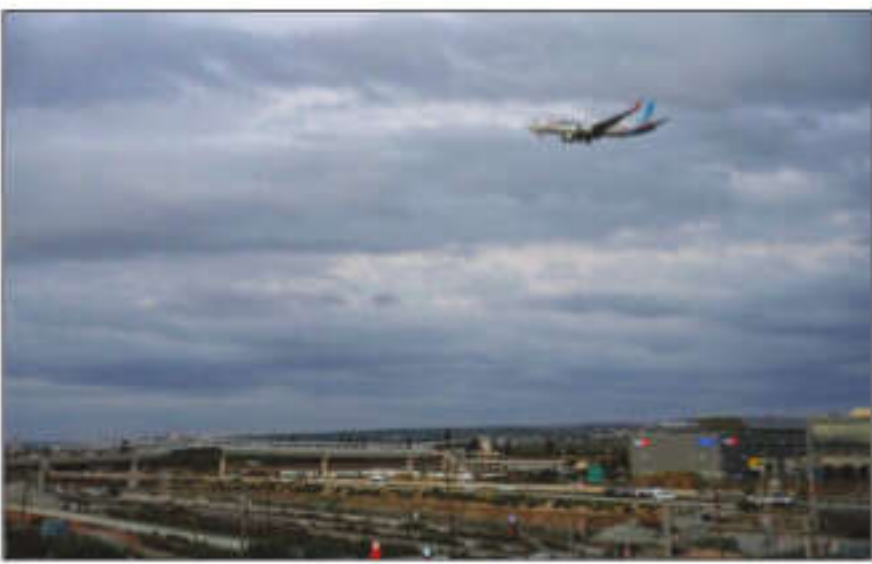
"I would say the answer, based on what I'm hearing, is yes, but we're working on it right now," Trump said. He did not elaborate about why he suspects Iran might be involved.

Asked if the US would retaliate against Tehran if it was behind the attack, Trump said, "Oh they'll be hit, very hard, don't worry."

"You just ask them," he added. "They know what happened. They'll be hit very hard."

His remarks came as diplomatic efforts to end the war appear to have stalled.

Iranian officials indicated Wednesday that they received



an official US response to Tehran's latest proposal to end the seven-month war, which Trump had publicly rejected just days earlier. The officials did not say what the response contained and whether it was a rejection.

Trump said in a Time magazine interview published

Thursday that he will not accept proposals from Iran that "he wouldn't have approved a year ago," and left open the possibility of resuming bombing after the 3 November election in the US.

Meanwhile, the American military has dispatched roughly 9,000 troops aboard a group

Omani co-pilot who stabbed Captain Smit Machchhar discussed killing Jews online

Jerusalem: The Omani co-pilot who stabbed Captain Smit Machchhar aboard the FlyDubai passenger flight reportedly discussed killing Jews on social media, an Israeli official told *The Times of Israel*. The official said the co-pilot had also asked Emirati crew members to kill him, citing accounts from passengers on the flight. The official described the suspect as someone willing to take his own life and alleged that his social media accounts showed signs of an Islamist mindset and a tilt towards jihadist ideology.

of ships to the Middle East, a US official said Thursday. That could mean three carriers will be in the region as soon as late October, according to the official, who spoke to agencies on condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive military operations. Despite Trump's

public rebuff, mediators have continued working with Iran and the US to try to broker a deal to end the fighting and open the Strait of Hormuz, according to officials who were not authorised to comment publicly and spoke on condition of anonymity.

Third US carrier, thousands of troops head to West Asia as Trump weighs Iran strikes

AGENCIES Washington, 2 October

The US military is dispatching roughly 9,000 troops aboard a group of ships to the Middle East, a US official said Thursday. The bolstering of the American military presence comes as President Donald Trump warned anew that new strikes against Iran could be on the horizon.

The troop movement, which includes a third aircraft carrier, underscores the rapidly evolving dynamic of Trump's war against Iran as he ponders his next move, with midterm elections in the United States looming large and new signs that the nature of the conflict may be becoming more complex.

Trump has threatened that



a post-midterm election escalation - despite his initial promises to Americans of a campaign that would last a matter of weeks - remains a viable option. Further complicating matters, Trump told reporters Thursday that early indications suggest that Iran is linked to the FlyDubai co-pilot who stabbed his captain and tried to crash an Israel-bound flight on Wednesday.

In an exchange with reporters at the White House, Trump raised the connection when asked by a reporter if there were any links between the pilot behind the attack and Tehran.

"I would say the answer, based on what I'm hearing, is 'yes,' but we're working on it right now," Trump said, without offering details.

Trump added that if the link to Iran is established, the United States would retaliate. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu claimed in a Fox News interview earlier Thursday that investigators believe the FlyDubai suspect underwent "Islamist, radical indoctrination" but did not provide further details.

"Oh, they'll be hit very hard, don't worry," Trump said.

Putin says Russia will use 'all weapons' in its arsenal if any of its territory is attacked

AGENCIES Washington, 2 October

President Vladimir Putin on Thursday reiterated Moscow's long-held position that Russia is not planning to attack European countries but will respond to aggression with "all weapons" in its arsenal.

In remarks at a foreign policy forum, Putin accused the West and Europe of escalating tensions by talking about preparing for a war with Moscow in the coming years, conducting military drills in the Baltic Sea, and seizing Russian vessels.

His remarks followed Moscow's warning to NATO that it would not hesitate to use nuclear weapons to defend Kaliningrad should any members

of the military alliance try to cut off the Baltic exclave from the rest of Russia.

Several Russian embassies in Europe this week issued statements that said Moscow has "information that NATO is preparing (an) air and naval blockade of Kaliningrad and (the) Kaliningrad region."

They accused European leaders of "playing a dangerous game" by saying Russia might attack another country or ramp up a campaign of destabilising attacks with drones and sabotage. Moscow has called the allegations absurd.

"There should be no mistake ~ Russia would be ready to use all its arsenal, including nuclear weapons, to defend its territory if NATO countries



try to isolate (the) Kaliningrad region from the rest of the country," the Russian Embassy in Ireland said in its statement on Tuesday.

Asked at the Valdai Club forum Thursday whether Russia was on the cusp of a war with NATO or whether both were trying to intimidate each other, Putin said: "It's not intimidation, it's a response to an attempt to intimidate us."

An Ebola treatment centre was burned down as the death toll in Congo passes 4,000

AGENCIES Bunia, 2 October

Congo's Ebola outbreak has recorded more than 4,000 deaths, authorities said, as they struggle to contain the spread of the virus.

The latest figures released by the Health Ministry on Thursday showed that 4,018 people have died, making up nearly half of the 8,300 confirmed cases, in what has become the fastest-growing Ebola outbreak in history.

Congo announced an

outbreak on 15 May, caused by the rare Bundibugyo virus, which has no known treatment or vaccine.

Some health workers gathered in Bunia, the capital of northeastern Ituri province, the heart of the outbreak. They were demanding payment for wages owed but were quickly dispersed by officials.

The protesting workers included surveillance team members, who identify people exposed to infected patients. They waved placards saying,

"No money, no data!" and "No payment for months."

Front-line workers have gone on strike several times since the outbreak began, further hampering efforts to contain the disease.

A senior United Nations official said that an Ebola-hit camp housing a transit center for infected patients was burned by soldiers earlier this week as they were looking for weapons in Kigonzo, on the outskirts of Bunia, forcing 19,000 people in the camp to flee.

Spanish protesters march on Parliament ahead of emergency housing vote

AGENCIES Madrid, 2 October

Spain's government looks set to lose two key votes it needs to ratify a package of emergency measures aimed at tackling the nation's housing affordability crisis when lawmakers convened on Friday, while protesters march on the Parliament demanding help for renters.

The Catalan separatist party Junts - essential for the approval of the two government decrees - said in a statement Friday morning that it will vote

against them. That appears to have doomed the measures when combined with the "No" from the center-right Popular Party and far-right Vox.

The likely defeat sparked speculation in Spanish media that Prime Minister Pedro S  nchez could consider bringing forward elections from next year. S  nchez didn't speak when he arrived at the chamber in downtown Madrid. His office did not immediately respond to questions from agencies regarding a possible snap election.



The government decrees were intended to quell a public uproar following the televised eviction of an 87-year-old woman last week in Madrid that sparked protests and a

camp-in that has occupied Madrid's most important square ever since. Barring a surprise, the progressive coalition of S  nchez will suffer a costly legislative defeat that will likely fan the flames of the protests.

Outside the parliament, protesters held up homemade signs with images of vultures on them, denouncing the real estate speculators they blame for driving up prices.

Protester Carla Cremonte, a 34-year-old office worker, lamented that the right-wing parties had

united to "vote against the interests of the majority of people who are here, of the workers of Spain."

"I don't know what might happen, whether elections will be called, but in the streets, we will continue fighting and the atmosphere is one of a general strike," she said.

The average rent in Spain has almost doubled in the past 10 years. The average price per square meter has risen from 8.20 euros in 2016 to 15.1 euros (\$17.15) this year, according to the real estate website Idealista.

LEISURE

BEETLE BAILEY

TIGER

DADDY DAZE

10 MINUTE CROSSWORD

ACROSS

1 Coldness (5)
4 Changes course (5)
7 Enfold (4)
8 Vague (8)
9 Disease of rabbits (11)
11 Slew (6)
13 Cunning (6)
14 Movie (7,4)
18 Aromatic shrub (8)
19 Farm building (4)
20 Stratum (5)
21 Sycophant (5)

DOWN

1 Abrupt (4)
2 Suggest (5)
3 Rugby restart (4-3)
4 Leg bone (5)
5 Preclude (4,3)
6 Scholarly (8)
10 Fit together neatly (8)
12 Ceramics (7)
13 Initially (2,5)
15 Jockey (5)
16 Zodiac sign (5)
17 Squirrel's nest (4)

SOLUTIONS TO LAST SATURDAY'S CROSSWORD

ACROSS:

1 Beech.
4 Bawl.
8 Pineapple.
9 Spa.
10 Slim.

11 Gradient.
16 Impertinent.
17 Trio.
20 She.
21 Tragedian.

DOWN:

1 Bypass.
2 Ennui.
3 Hear.
4 Breeding.
5 Western.
6 Operational.

7 Last.
12 Pedestal.
14 Machete.
15 Bounty.
16 Busy.
18 Reiki.
19 Menu.

Solution to yesterday's puzzle

Sudoku is a number placing puzzle based on a 9x9 grid with several given numbers. The object is to place the numbers 1 to 9 in the empty squares so that no row, no column and no 3x3 box contains the same number. The difficulty level increases through the week.

NEED TO KNOW

1. Centralized Emergency Services (Pan-India)

The most significant change since that clipping was printed is the rollout of India's unified emergency response network. Fragmented local numbers have been integrated: National Emergency Integrated Helpline: 112 (Instantly dispatches Police, Fire, or Medical emergencies without needing individual local landlines). National Ambulance Service: 102 (Dedicated, free state-run medical transit across West Bengal). Police Control (Direct): 100. Fire Services (Direct): 101. 2. Blood Banks (Updated to 10-Digit Formats) Local landlines in Kolkata now require the 033 city code when dialed from mobile devices. The major local banks from the list remain core institutions but with updated exchange configurations: Central Blood Bank (Mankilda) 033-23510619 / 033-23510620 Peoples Blood Bank (Bowanipore) 033-24555164 / 033-24555557 RK Mission Seva Pratishthan 033-24763636 (Non corporate exchange line) Ashok Laboratory / Blood Bank: 033-24720333 Life Care Blood Bank: 033-22846940 Howrah District Blood Bank: 033-2611227 3. 24-Hour Medical Oxygen Delivery BOC India Ltd: The 8-digit mobile number listed in the clipping (983127777) is no longer a public hotline. BOC India has officially re-branded as Linde India Limited. Their central administrative headquarters (Oxygen House on Taratala Road, Kolkata) coordinates institutional supply at 033-24014708. Note for Consumers: For standard domestic home oxygen cylinders, citizens now rely on local medical oxygen aggregators or local emergency club desks. 4. Civic Services & Utilities Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC): The old 7-digit lines have been upgraded to dedicated toll-free helplines and digital bots: Toll-Free Control Room: 1800-345-3375 or 1800-33-3375. Central Lines: 033-22861212 / 033-22861313 WhatsApp Grievance Bot: 8335988888 CESC Fault Reporting: The 4-digit number 1912 has been modernized nationwide to 1912 (and secondary line 033-44031912). WhatsApp reporting desk: 7439001912. 5. Police & Regional HS Lines Lalbazar (Central Police Control Room) 033-22143230/033-22143024 Bhawanibhawan (CID HQ): 033-24791761 / 033-24791933 Salt Lake Fire Station: 033-23575293 6. Indian Railways (Howrah, Sealdah, Shalimar) Integrated Railway Helpline: 139 7. Outdated Telecom & Transit Features : Kolkata Traffic Police Control Room via WhatsApp at 9830010000 or by dialing 1073. Taxi Refusal via SMS (57575), Calcutta Telephones (1951, 1952, 1953), BSNL helpline at 1500.

epaper.thestatesman.com

BRIEFLY

Canara Bank Kolkata circle organises ‘Swachhata Hi Seva’ campaign:

Kolkata: Canara Bank, Kolkata circle, organised a ‘Swachhata Hi Seva’ campaign on 1 October 2026 at its circle office premises in Kolkata, reaffirming the Bank’s commitment towards cleanliness, sanitation and responsible citizenship.

The cleanliness drive was conducted in the presence of Manoj Kumar Meena, General Manager & circle head, Canara Bank, Kolkata circle, along with Deputy General Managers, other executives and staff members of the circle office.

Saroj Poddar Group, Keventer join hands for category II real estate debt AIF:

Kolkata: Poddar Keventer Capital Advisors Private Limited has launched its maiden Category II AIF, focused on secured real estate debt opportunities, making it the first AIF launch by a real estate developer from West Bengal. The fund targets a corpus of Rs 400 crore, expandable to Rs 600 crore through a Rs 200 crore greenshoe option. The AIF marks the coming together of Saroj Poddar Group, a USD 3 billion diversified business conglomerate, and Keventer Group, one of Eastern India’s leading business groups, with established businesses across Food & FMCG and Real Estate.

Centre expands support across agri and allied sectors to boost rural livelihoods: Sitharaman

AGENCIES
New Delhi, 2 October

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday said the Central government has expanded its support across agriculture and allied sectors by working closely with state governments to improve livelihoods in rural areas.

Addressing a gathering in Madanapalle, Andhra Pradesh, the finance minister said initiatives such as mobile veterinary units and the deployment of veterinarians across districts are helping strengthen the dairy and fisheries sectors, creating new income opportunities for farmers and rural households.

“Working together with state governments, the Centre has expanded support across



agriculture and allied sectors, deploying mobile veterinary units and veterinarians across districts to boost dairy and fisheries livelihoods,” she said.

FM Sitharaman said the Centre and the Andhra Pradesh government are committed to transforming Rayalaseema into “Ratnala Seema” or a land of prosperity, backed by the decisive mandate received by the NDA government in 2024.

Highlighting the state’s development vision, she said

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu has envisaged an ambitious Rs 1 lakh crore initiative covering 10 districts, including the eight districts of Rayalaseema and two adjoining districts, to create a world-class Global Horticulture Hub.

According to the Finance Minister, the initiative is being launched with the support of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and multilateral institutions such as the World Bank, the Asian Development Bank (ADB) and other agencies.

The project aims to bring advanced technologies to the region, improve water-use efficiency and enhance agricultural productivity.

FM Sitharaman said the government is focusing on ensuring that every drop of water is used efficiently, particularly in water-stressed regions, through the adoption of modern farming practices and technological interventions.

“To make agriculture climate-resilient, scientifically developed seed varieties have been introduced to withstand extreme heat and dry spells,” she stated.

“Through the GOBARdhan initiative, rural waste is converted into clean biogas, while solar pumps under PM-KUSUM provide farmers with reliable, free, solar-powered electricity for irrigation. To protect farmers against crop losses and unforeseen risks, the PM Fasal Bima Yojana provides robust crop insurance,” FM Sitharaman stated.

The Finance Minister also highlighted various farmer-centric schemes introduced by the Centre to strengthen agricultural resilience and improve farm incomes.

Petrol, diesel demand rise in Sept; LPG consumption falls nearly 9 pc: Report

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

India’s consumption of petrol and diesel increased in September, even as LPG demand continued to weaken amid supply disruptions and efforts to reduce dependence on imported cooking gas, preliminary data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC) showed.

Petrol sales rose 7.21 per cent year-on-year (YoY) to 3.64 million tonnes (mt) in September, compared with the corresponding period last year. Diesel demand, which accounts for the largest share of petroleum product consumption in the country, increased 4.86 per cent to 7.12 mt.

In contrast, LPG consumption

declined 9.15 per cent YoY to 2.64 mt during the month.

The decline in LPG demand comes against the backdrop of continued supply challenges linked to the West Asia crisis, which began in late February. India relies significantly on imported LPG, with a substantial portion of supplies moving through the Strait of Hormuz. Disruptions along the key shipping route have affected the availability of the cooking fuel and prompted measures to curb dependence on imports.

The government has also been encouraging a shift towards piped natural gas (PNG), particularly in areas where the network is accessible. Incentives have been extended to city gas distribution companies to expand PNG connections

and encourage eligible LPG users to make the switch.

The measures, along with tighter LPG availability during the crisis, have contributed to a sustained decline in consumption in recent months.

Demand for aviation turbine fuel (ATF), meanwhile, remained broadly unchanged in September. ATF consumption stood at around 720,000 tonnes, almost the same as the level recorded a year earlier. The broader consumption trend during the first six months of the financial year also showed stronger demand for transport fuels. Between April and September 2026, petrol consumption increased 7 per cent YoY to 22.67 mt. Diesel demand dimmed 4.85 per cent to 47.89 mt during the period.

Piyush Goyal calls for WTO-compliant measures to address global trade distortions

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has called for trade measures to address global production and trade distortions to remain consistent with World Trade Organization (WTO) rules, while cautioning against shifting the adjustment burden onto developing economies.

Speaking at the concluding day of the G20 Trade Ministers’ Meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin, Goyal said India did not face structural excess capacity in the sectors identified under the G20 presidency. He highlighted India’s domestic-demand-driven economy and its expanding

manufacturing value chains as part of its role in global supply chains.

Goyal said concerns over trade-distorting support and its potential impact on competition could be addressed through established WTO mechanisms, including anti-dumping and countervailing duties. Such measures, he said, should be supported by evidence and remain subject to judicial review.

The minister also argued that industrial capacity by itself should not be treated as a trade problem. According to him, distortions could emerge when production becomes geographically concentrated because of hidden subsidies or other forms of support. While



diversification of production and supply chains is a legitimate objective, he said it should not become a justification for measures that fall outside WTO rules. On the proposed updating of the Most-Favoured-Nation (MFN) principle, Goyal said India’s trade relations with G20 economies depend on a transparent, non-discriminatory and rules-based system. He stressed that MFN treatment remains an important element

of that framework and called for preserving special and differential treatment for developing countries.

Goyal also backed efforts to restore the WTO’s two-tier dispute settlement system, while stressing that consensus-based decision-making should remain central to the organisation.

Addressing the issue of forced labour in global supply chains, Goyal said India’s opposition to forced labour was “absolute and unconditional”. He pointed to Article 23 of the Constitution, which prohibits forced labour, as well as India’s ratification of International Labour Organization (ILO) Conventions 29 and 105. He also highlighted India’s

July 2026 amendment to its Foreign Trade Policy, which prohibits imports of goods produced using forced labour.

At the same time, Goyal said trade-related action at borders should be based on specific and verifiable evidence rather than assumptions involving entire countries, regions or sectors. Such measures, he said, should follow due process and comply with WTO rules.

India supported cooperation among G20 members to eliminate forced labour and exchange best practices, he said, while opposing arrangements that could lead to member monitoring, create new obligations or provide the basis for unilateral trade action.

Celebrating 50 years of engineering excellence

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
Kolkata, 2 October

Conveyor & Ropeway Services Pvt. Ltd. (CRSPL), a Kolkata-based engineering company specialising in ropeway and material-handling solutions, is celebrating five decades of its journey.

Established in 1975, CRSPL has evolved from an Indian ropeway engineering enterprise into a company working across passenger ropeways, urban aerial mobility, material transportation, coal washery and associated engineering services. The Golden Jubilee is an opportunity to celebrate not only the company’s milestones, but also the engineers, employees, partners, clients and institutions who have contributed to its journey.

Its capabilities today cover the complete project lifecycle



~ from feasibility studies and DPR preparation to design, engineering, manufacturing, construction, commissioning and operation & maintenance.

The company’s present portfolio includes passenger ropeways, urban transportation systems, material-handling

ropeways and coal-washing solutions. CRSPL currently highlights a portfolio of more than 130 projects and more than 50 years of industry experience.

A key part of CRSPL’s current innovation programme is CURVO, its patented

non-linear ropeway technology developed for urban transportation. CURVO is designed to allow ropeway alignments to negotiate curves and bends, addressing some of the limitations of conventional straight-line ropeway systems and opening

possibilities for integration into complex urban environments.

In 2026, CRSPL entered into a memorandum of understanding with IIT Roorkee & IIST for collaboration in ropeway technology research and development, with CURVO among the key areas of focus.

At the heart of CRSPL’s 50-year journey are the people who built, operated and continuously improved its systems.

The company’s leadership and engineering legacy have played a significant role in developing indigenous ropeway and material-handling capabilities. Founder and Managing Director Shekhar Chakravarty has been associated with the development of ropeway technology and urban mobility innovations for several decades.

Energy price shock puts governments under growing fiscal pressure: UN report

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Governments across the world are facing mounting difficulty in protecting households from soaring energy and food costs as the economic fallout from the Iran war, high borrowing costs and extreme weather puts pressure on public finances, according to a new United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) report.

The UNDP said government spending on fuel subsidies could exceed \$1 trillion this year as countries expand measures such as price controls, subsidies and tax rebates to limit the impact of higher energy prices on consumers. The report warned that

governments could find it increasingly difficult to sustain such support, particularly as crude oil prices approach \$100 a barrel and elevated interest rates raise the cost of servicing public debt.

“The horizon over the next few weeks and months is uncertain because we don’t see a very clear pathway out of the three-pronged crisis,” UNDP Chief Economist George Gray Molina said, referring to the conflict involving Iran, elevated borrowing costs and the El Niño weather phenomenon.

The UNDP analysis, based on data from the World Bank, International Monetary Fund and International Energy Agency, found that the number

of countries introducing measures to cushion consumers from rising prices nearly doubled between April and September.

Such interventions have helped prevent a significant increase in poverty, the report said. Without the relief measures introduced by governments, an estimated 130 million additional people could have fallen below the \$6.85-a-day poverty threshold this year.

However, the UNDP cautioned that the pressure on governments is likely to intensify in the coming months. The combined effects of the economic and geopolitical shocks are expected to reach their peak in early 2027, with weather-related disruptions adding to concerns over food security.

India must keep growth momentum, focus on competition-friendly economy: Finance Ministry

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

India cannot afford to become complacent about its strong economic growth as geopolitical tensions and global financial uncertainty intensify, the Finance Ministry said in its latest Monthly Economic Review, calling for faster, consistent and high-quality policy decisions to maintain investor confidence.

The review said India needs to move beyond being merely “business-friendly” and build an economy that encourages greater competition. According to the Department of Economic Affairs officials who authored the review, stronger competition would be critical to creating an economy capable of

delivering higher innovation and manufacturing growth.

The ministry also highlighted the importance of better governance and stronger state capacity in improving India’s competitive environment. Consistent and predictable policy decisions, it said, would help reassure investors at a time when global economic conditions remain uncertain.

The warning comes amid greater caution among foreign investors toward Indian equities. Rising global bond yields, tariff-related uncertainty and concerns around India’s positioning in artificial intelligence have contributed to pressure on foreign portfolio flows.

Despite these challenges, the Finance Ministry expects India’s economic

expansion to remain strong. It has projected real GDP growth of 7.3 per cent for the September quarter of FY27, following a 7.8 per cent expansion in the June quarter.

The review said economic activity has continued to hold up in the early part of the second quarter, although the pace of expansion could moderate. It stressed that India’s post-pandemic growth performance cannot be taken for granted and will need to be sustained through continued policy action.

Agriculture and rural demand could provide additional support to the economy, the ministry said. Monsoon conditions have been more favourable than initially expected, while kharif sowing remains



broadly close to last year’s levels across several crops. However, the outlook for the rabi season will need to be monitored, particularly in view of evolving weather conditions.

The ministry also flagged risks to growth from inflation and global monetary conditions. Higher interest rates in developed economies could push up domestic bond

yields and reduce the attractiveness of emerging-market assets, potentially slowing cross-border capital flows.

Inflation risks could also increase because of a combination of climate-related disruptions, geopolitical tensions and higher crude oil prices. The review pointed to the possibility of a strong El Niño affecting the upcoming rabi crop through higher temperatures and lower soil moisture. A favourable Indian Ocean Dipole, however, could provide some offset.

Higher global crude prices could add to India’s imported inflation pressures, particularly against the backdrop of tighter monetary conditions globally. The US Federal Reserve’s 25-basis-point

rate increase in September was also cited among the factors that could influence domestic financial conditions.

At the same time, the Reserve Bank of India’s recent liquidity management operations could help keep financial conditions balanced and prevent excessive demand-side pressures, the review said. Festive-season demand and elevated input costs may create temporary price pressures, while government measures on the supply side could help contain their impact.

On the external sector, the Finance Ministry highlighted the continued strength of India’s goods and services exports. At the current pace, exports during the first five months of the financial year are close to

\$400 billion, putting the country on course to potentially approach the \$1 trillion mark in total exports for the full year.

The review attributed part of the export momentum to India’s expanding network of trade agreements and said additional agreements could provide further support to India’s external trade.

Overall, the ministry said sustaining high growth will depend on maintaining macroeconomic stability, strengthening economic resilience and improving the quality of policymaking. For India, the challenge now is not simply achieving high growth, but ensuring that the momentum is sustained quarter after quarter amid an increasingly uncertain global environment.

Remembering India’s Most Iconic Woman Entertainer

SUBHASH KJHA

It is said in the Hindi film industry and not wrongly that Lata Mangeshkar could make or break a shooting schedule. Sets were dismantled when she felt her voice was not up to the mark on a particular day. Producers waited for weeks and months for Lataji to return from her concerts abroad to record their songs.

Lataji defines six generations of beauty, grace and melody in Hindi cinema. Or as the ebullient Dev Anand once described it: “If Lata sneezed the whole industry caught a cold.”

So how powerful was Lata Mangeshkar? And we are not talking about the power that comes from the zeros in your bank account. It’s another kind of power, a power that comes from possessing a rare kind of talent that incites a worshipful awe and reverence. I remember entering a restaurant with Lataji and her sister and the minute we entered, all conversation on the tables ceased completely. Every patron, man or woman, adult or grownup, was on his or her feet. That was the magic of Lataji.

When seen in public no one came forward to speak to her or get a picture from her: they just stood and watched her with admiration. Says diehard Latabhakt Jaya Bachchan, “When one sees her for the first time, the feeling is indescribable. That she actually existed is like a miracle. When I saw her for the first time I just kept staring at her open-mouthed. I think she was used to it.”

Sanjay Leela Bhansali who says he learnt direction by listening to her singing says for many years he didn’t



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want to meet his idol. “I didn’t want my reverence for her to be eroded. I would just find excuses to drive past Prabhu Kunj (Lataji’s residence) hoping that she would pass by on her balcony. But she never did.” Then when Bhansali finally met his Mata Saraswati, he was struck by the aura. “She exuded a serenity, and a godliness that was just mesmerizing. Just sitting with her I felt close to God,” adds Bhansali.

This kind of veneration is unknown to civilization. As my dear friend Javed Akhtar puts it, “It begins and ends with her.” What made Lata Mangeshkar one of her kind was not only her extraordinary singing talent, she was also a woman way ahead of

her times who worked in the viciously patriarchal Mumbai film industry on her own terms. Lataji was just 13 when she had to fend for her family. When her father the great Pandit Dinanath Mangeshkar was on his deathbed, it was clear that little Lata had suddenly grown up. Sister Asha Bhosle recalled how Lataji summoned all the siblings around her ailing father, she then commanded her sister Asha to get a thali and a lota filled

with water. Little Lata then poured the water in the thali, put her father’s feet in the thali and told her siblings to drink the water as god’s charanamrit. From the tender age of 13 Lataji



went out to search for work. She once said “I did some acting though I hated it. But I had no choice. I was suddenly the only earning member of my family. I had to look after my mother, three sisters and one brother. Luckily my career as a singer took off in no time. I was soon recording two to three songs per day. There was no time for

any of the things that girls my age did. My dolls were all forgotten.”

Lataji remained single all her life. In 1949 when Lataji’s career took off in a big way with a slew of sensational chartbusters she demanded, and got, the name of the singer on the record. Prior to this the name on the record was that of the character played by the actress for whom Lataji ghost-voiced. In the 1960s she fought a valiant copyright battle for royalty money for playback singers, and won.

Known to be extremely charitable and kind to those whom she was close to, she never charged Hrishikesh Mukherjee a single penny for any of the classics she sang in his cinema. Lataji never allowed anyone to take her for granted. Nor would she compromise on the quality of her work. If she felt her voice was not up to the recording she would cancel at the last minute. Sets were known to be dismantled because she refused to sing in a less than perfect voice. As she explained to me once, “For the producer, it was a job done. But for me it was there for posterity, I couldn’t compromise on the quality of my voice.” Not many know this, but Lataji was the first female working professional in the Hindi film industry to raise her voice against harassment. The singer was a top playback name before Mohd Rafi. He would find excuses to make improper comments. One day he commented on a necklace she was wearing. Lataji walked out of the recording (for the formidable Naushad) and vowed to never sing with that singer again. She never did.

THE WRITER IS AN EMINENT FILM CRITIC.



Wild Horse Nine: A Tale of Male Bonding and Mortality

GAUTAMAN BHASKARAN

We have to admit foreign cinema has this ability to turn out fascinating ideas. Look, for instance, at the late Abbas Kiarostami’s Ten, which opened in 2002. It may unspool like a documentary, but is actually fiction. About a woman taxi driver (essayed by Mania Akbari) in Tehran, the director lets us peek into the lives and problems faced by women in his country. The premise may sound boring, but the movie has enough drama to keep us engaged. Featuring conversations between the driver and the passengers who hop into her cab, the film also gives us a tour of Tehran. What is much more interesting is her dialogue with her rebellious son, Amin Maher (played by her real son, Amin Maher).

Wild Horse Nine in English from Martin McDonagh’s stable has a similar plot, although there are just two main characters here, and their lively exchanges do not let a dull moment creep into the narrative. One of the memorable titles of the recent Venice Film Festival, the movie begins as two CIA agents meet in Chile. The two take off on an

assignment before the coup. What a strange pair!

Like most of McDonagh’s pictures, his latest is also about male bonding and friendship. Chris (John Malkovich) and Lee (Sam Rockwell) are operatives and have been in the field for a long time. Their latest assignment is connected to the fall of Chilean President Salvador Allende’s government through a coup. He was the first democratically elected Marxist leader in Latin America.

But years of violence have not hardened Chris. On the contrary, he is softening, and in one scene admits that he feels guilty even when he kills moths. He traps them and releases them outside. One reason for this change of attitude is his spreading cancer that is all set to kill him. And his dementia is fogging his brain.

In the final analysis, Wild Horse Nine is a story of mortality. But it has been disguised as a political thriller. However, be that as it may, the work is subtle and classy. Much of the credit for this must go to Malkovich, who commands the screen as effortlessly as ever.

THE WRITER IS A MOVIE CRITIC AND AUTHOR

Look Again. It Isn’t Gone

VEDANTA DASGUPTA

You return to a place you knew as a child. The road is wider. The trees are gone. The old building has been replaced by something taller. Perhaps even the shop you remember has disappeared. But you still know where everything used to be.

SO WHERE DID THE PAST GO?

That question sits quietly at the heart of Temporal Materialities, curated by Rashmee Pal Chouteau. The exhibition brings together six artists, Debasish Mukherjee, Megha Joshi, Pooja Iranna, Ruchika Wason Singh, Samindranath Majumdar and Sheetal Gattani, around a deceptively simple proposition: can material hold time? It is a question that sounds like it belongs to a gallery. But it really begins outside one.

We know that matter remembers. An archaeological object can outlive the civilisation that made it. An old wall can carry traces of the colours that once covered it. A staircase becomes smooth because thousands of people have walked across it.

THE PAST MAY DISAPPEAR FROM SIGHT, BUT THAT DOES NOT NECESSARILY MEAN IT HAS DISAPPEARED ALTOGETHER.

Debasish Mukherjee’s work makes this idea personal. After spending the first seventeen years of his life in a railway colony in Chhapra, Bihar, Mukherjee returned years later to find much of the landscape of his childhood almost erased by development. The colony had changed, but his memory had not. Working with graphite and acrylic, he creates an abstract map of remembered routes, vanished structures and altered geographies. It is not a map of Chhapra as it exists today. It is a map of the Chhapra that still exists somewhere inside him.

And perhaps that is the first contradiction of disappearance.

A PLACE CAN BE PHYSICALLY GONE AND STILL REMAIN STUBBORNLY PRESENT

Pooja Iranna takes that contradiction from the personal to the urban. Her works look at cities caught in a relentless cycle of construction, demolition and reconstruction. Buildings rise, disappear and are



replaced, often until the distinctive character of a place begins to dissolve. Her works ask an uncomfortable question: when we keep building the future, what exactly are we destroying from the past?

For the exhibition, Iranna has worked with stone for the first time. The material seems almost deliberately resistant to the world she depicts. Stone suggests weight, age and permanence. Yet even permanence becomes uncertain when everything around it is being rebuilt.

But disappearance is not always architectural.

SOMETIMES IT IS HUMAN

Megha Joshi works with diya bati, or solte, the cotton wicks used in Hindu rituals. The making of these wicks is repetitive, meditative and labour-intensive. Joshi makes that repetition visible, turning time spent working into part of the artwork itself. Yet her works are deliberately critical rather than devotional. The ritual material becomes a way of questioning patriarchal structures and drawing attention to women’s labour, which is so often performed without recognition.

Suddenly, repetition does not seem so mundane.

Doing something again and again can leave a history of its own.

That history becomes visible in Ruchika Wason Singh’s paintings. Her surfaces accumulate marks, scratches and gestures. Forms emerge, disappear and return, bringing different moments into the same space. The effect is uncannily close to memory. We rarely remember anything exactly as it happened. We cover parts of it, recover others and sometimes discover



that something we thought was forgotten has been sitting there all along.

Sheetal Gattani makes this process almost impossible to miss. She builds her paintings through repeated application and removal. Colour is added, scraped away and exposed again. Charcoal settles into lines and grooves before another layer begins. What is removed therefore remains, hidden beneath what comes next. Her surfaces become records of their own making.

It is tempting to think of erasure as an act of disappearance.

BUT WHAT IF ERASURE IS ALSO A FORM OF PRESERVATION?

Samindranath Majumdar’s paintings seem to wrestle with precisely this idea. His surfaces are continually altered, masked, scraped and reworked. What finally remains is not simply the finished picture but the evidence of everything that happened before it. His landscapes become psychological

spaces, absorbing personal and environmental tensions through the act of painting.

By now, the question that began the exhibition starts to feel less like an art-world puzzle and more like an ordinary human problem.



WHAT HAPPENS TO THE THINGS WE LOSE?

The house is demolished. The neighbourhood changes. The ritual evolves. The labour goes unnoticed. The painting is scraped down. Yet something remains.

A route remembered. A mark beneath another mark. A layer of colour. Hours of invisible work. A landscape that exists nowhere except in someone’s memory.

Perhaps this is what Temporal Materialities wants us to reconsider. We often imagine time as a force that destroys. But time can also accumulate. It settles into surfaces, objects, places and gestures. The exhibition describes material as gathering traces of environments, memories, gestures and transformations.

So perhaps the question is not whether the past survives.

Perhaps the more interesting question is where it has been hiding.

Under the new building. Inside the remembered map.

Beneath the latest layer of paint.

In the hands that performed the same task a thousand times.

In the artwork that refuses to be just an object.

The exhibition remains on view until 30 October, giving the works a little more time to do what they seem to ask of us: to slow down, look again and notice what has remained.

Look again. It isn’t gone.



Chahal retires

Veteran Indian leg-spinner Yuzvendra Chahal on Friday announced his retirement from first-class cricket, acknowledging that his long-cherished dream of earning a Test cap was no longer within reach, while adding that he remains committed to competing in white-ball formats.

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12
Mumbai
Saturday, 03 October 2026



Asian Games Day 13: Six golds push India to No 5 as tally rises to 76

TRIDIB BAPARNASH
New Delhi, 2 October

India produced their richest gold-medal haul of the Asian Games on Friday, winning six titles on a stunning Day 13 in Aichi-Nagoya, with the women's hockey team providing the most stirring finish by ending a four-decade wait for the continental crown. The hockey gold came alongside top finishes for the women's recurve team, boxer Lovlina Borgohain, Parveen Hooda and Ankush Panghal, and wrestler Sujeet Kalkal, lifting India's tally to 76 medals — 16 gold, 25 silver and 35 bronze — and moving them up to fifth in the standings.

Captain Salima Tete and her team brought the day to a memorable close by beating defending champions China 1-0 in the women's hockey final, with Lalremsiami Hmarzote scoring the decisive goal in the 10th minute before a determined Indian defence held firm under relentless pressure.

Earlier, Ankita Bhakat, Kumkum Mohod and Kirti Sharma had made history by beating powerhouse South Korea 5-3 to win India's first Asiad gold in the women's recurve team event. Lovlina then celebrated her 29th birthday with gold in the women's 75kg boxing final, while Parveen won the women's 65kg title and Ankush Panghal claimed gold in the men's 80kg category.



(L-R) China's Ziyi Bao (silver), India's Lovlina Borgohain (gold), Kazakhstan's Natalia Bogdanova (bronze), and Vietnam's Luu Diem Quynh (bronze) from the women's 75kg boxing category pose with their medals on the podium at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games 2026, in Nishio, Aichi, on Friday. AGENCIES

Sujeet completed India's golden run with a stunning late comeback in the men's freestyle 65kg final, overturning a 9-2 deficit against Tajikistan's Abdulmazzhid Kudiev to win 10-9 with just 11 seconds remaining.

The six golds lifted India from eighth to fifth in the standings, behind China, hosts Japan, South Korea and Uzbekistan.

Women's hockey team qualify for 2028 LA Olympics: The women's hockey team delivered one of the most significant results of India's campaign by beating China 1-0 at the Gifu Prefectural Green Stadium. The result not only ended India's wait for a women's

Asian Games hockey gold that stretched back to the 1982 edition in New Delhi, but also helped Salima Tete's side earn direct qualification for the Los Angeles Olympics in 2028.

Lalremsiami marked her 200th international appearance with the winning goal in the 10th minute, producing a superb reverse-stick strike after being picked out by Sakshi Rana.

China, the Paris Olympics silver medallists, responded with sustained pressure but found India's defence difficult to break down. Goalkeeper Bichu Devi was particularly influential, producing a crucial penalty-stroke save to preserve India's lead.

Archers make history: India's

first gold of the day came from the women's recurve team, with Ankita Bhakat, Kumkum Mohod and Kirti Sharma beating South Korea 5-3.

The victory ended South Korea's run of seven successive Asian Games women's recurve team titles dating back to Bangkok 1998 and gave India their first gold in the event. India then added two silver medals in recurve archery.

Kumkum and Dhiraj Bommadevara lost 3-5 to China's Zhu Jingyi and Li Mengqi in the mixed team final. China won the opening two sets 38-34 and 37-35 before India took the third 37-36. The fourth ended 37-37, giving China the title.

The defeat also meant India

missed the chance to secure the men's and women's recurve quota places for Los Angeles 2028 that were available to the mixed team champions.

Dhiraj later combined with Neeraj and Yashdeep Bhoje in the men's recurve team final, where India lost 1-5 to South Korea. It was their second successive silver in the event after finishing runners-up at Hangzhou 2023.

India will have more opportunities to secure Olympic quota places in the individual events on Saturday, with Kumkum, Dhiraj and Neeraj Chauhan through to the quarterfinals.

Lovlina leads boxing's record haul: Lovlina Borgohain's birthday gold headlined India's most successful Asian Games boxing campaign in terms of titles won. The 29-year-old defeated China's Ziyi Bao 5-0 in the women's 75kg final to upgrade the silver she won at Hangzhou 2023.

Parveen Hooda followed with a 3-2 victory over Chinese Taipei's Paris 2024 Olympic bronze medallist Chen Nien-Chin in the women's 65kg final, while Ankush Panghal beat South Korea's Kim Min-seong 4-0 in the men's 80kg final.

India finished with six boxing medals — three gold and three bronze — surpassing their previous best of two golds at the 2010 Guangzhou Games.

Kapil Pokhariya, Narender Berwal and Priya Ghanghas had earlier secured

bronze medals.

Sujeet's stunning turnaround: Sujeet Kalkal produced one of the day's most dramatic finishes in the men's freestyle 65kg final.

Trailing Tajikistan's Abdulmazzhid Kudiev 9-2 with just 1 minute and 40 seconds remaining, Sujeet launched a remarkable fightback, producing three takedowns in quick succession to cut the deficit to 9-8.

With Kudiev trying to run down the clock, Sujeet found one final opening and completed a two-point takedown with 11 seconds left to win 10-9. The victory gave India their first Asian Games wrestling gold since Bajrang Punia and Vinesh Phogat won titles at Jakarta 2018. Bajrang's gold had also come in the 65kg category.

India also added bronze medals in sailing and sepak takraw, with Nethra Kumanan winning a sailing bronze and the men's quadrathlon team securing a bronze in sepak takraw.

Neeru to carry flag at closing ceremony: Trap shooter Neeru Dhanda was named India's flag bearer for Sunday's closing ceremony after winning three medals in Aichi-Nagoya. Neeru has won two golds and a silver, becoming the first Indian to win an individual Asian Games gold in trap shooting. She also won silver in the women's trap team event before adding mixed trap team gold.

Birthday gold for Lovlina as India rewrite Asian Games boxing record

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Tokyo Olympics medallist Lovlina Borgohain gave herself the perfect 29th birthday present, winning the Asian Games gold on Friday as India signed off their boxing campaign on a high with Parveen Hooda and Ankush Panghal also topping the podium at the Aichi-Nagoya Games.

Overall, India finished with six medals - three gold and as many bronze - to mark their most successful Asian Games boxing campaign in terms of titles won. Guangzhou 2010 saw India bag two golds.

Lovlina defeated China's Ziyi Bao 5-0 in the women's 75kg final at the Nishio Gymnasium, completing a memorable campaign and upgrading the silver she won at the Hangzhou Asian Games in 2023.

"It's a very special birthday, and I think I have already celebrated because I got gold," she said.

Lovlina became only the second Indian woman after Mary Kom, who won gold at the 2014 Asian Games in Incheon, to claim an Asian Games boxing title.

The Assam boxer began the final cautiously against Bao, the reigning Asian Championships gold medallist, before using her experience to control the contest and secure a unanimous decision.

Lovlina had earlier beaten South Korea's Seong Suyeon 5-0 in the quarterfinals before

edging past Kazakhstan's reigning world champion Natalya Bogdanova 3-2 in a closely fought semifinal.

For Lovlina, the victory was also a continuation of her strong run in the 75kg category, where she has established herself as one of India's leading boxers over the past few years.

Lovlina's triumph was followed by gold medals for Parveen Hooda and Ankush Panghal.

Redemption for Parveen: Three years after her Hangzhou Asiad bronze medal was stripped for a whereabouts violation and missed the Paris Olympics during her suspension, Parveen proved her critics wrong by winning the gold after a hard-fought win against Chinese Taipei's Paris Olympic bronze medallist Chen Nien-Chin 3-2 in the women's 65kg final.

The Indian took all five judges' cards in the opening round before Chen fought back in the second. The final round was closely contested, but Parveen held on to secure the split decision.

Ankush ends 8-year wait for India's men's boxing gold: Ankush then completed India's golden run by beating South Korea's Kim Min-seong 4-0 in the men's 80kg final. With that, he also became the first Indian male boxer since Amit Panghal in 2018 to win gold at the continental showpiece.

India look to fix bowling concerns in series finale against West Indies

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

India will look to wrap up the ODI series on a stronger note with the ball when they take on the West Indies in the third and final match in Mullanpur on Saturday.

India have already sealed the three-match series after convincing wins in the first two games, but their bowling attack has had a difficult time on surfaces that have heavily favoured the batters.

India's bowlers have taken only one wicket in the first 10 overs across the two matches and conceded 177 runs in the powerplays. They have also struggled to make regular breakthroughs in the middle overs, leaving Kuldeep Yadav with much of the responsibility for taking wickets.

Gill will now have a chance to finish the series with another big score, while Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli have also

contributed with the bat. With only four Indian batters having batted in the series so far, KL Rahul, debutant Naman Dhir and Jadeja could be in line for more time in the middle.

The pace bowling combination remains the bigger talking point. With Prasidh Krishna ruled out of the final ODI with a left hamstring injury, Anshul Kamboj has been added to the squad. In that scenario, Mohammed Siraj could return after sitting out the first two matches and would bring experience to an attack that has struggled to contain the West Indies top order.

Mullanpur will host its first men's ODI, and India's bowlers will hope the pitch offers more assistance than the tracks in Thiruvananthapuram and Guwahati. Nitish Kumar Reddy could also be considered for a longer bowling role after being left out of the second game.

India break S Korea's long reign to win historic recurve gold

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

At 17, Kumkum Mohod delivered a performance well beyond her years to help India create history in women's recurve archery at the Asian Games, anchoring a remarkable victory over South Korea in the gold-medal final.

South Korea had dominated this event like few other teams. In the previous 12 editions of the women's recurve team competition at the Asian Games, they had won 10 gold medals and had not lost since 1994, putting together seven successive titles. India finally ended that run on Thursday.

Kumkum, Ankita Bhakat and Kirti Sharma held their nerve to beat the defending champions and win India's first-ever Asian Games gold in the women's recurve team event.

Wrestler Sujeet Kalkal completes journey with Asiad gold

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

Three years after a legal battle over his Asian Games selection, Sujeet Kalkal completed a remarkable journey by becoming an Asian Games champion, producing a stunning comeback to beat Tajikistan's world medallist Abdulmazzhid Kudiev 10-9 in the men's freestyle 65kg final.

Trailing 2-9 with just under two minutes left, Sujeet refused to surrender. The 23-year-old launched a relentless series of attacks, scoring three takedowns in quick succession to close the gap. Kudiev was still clinging to a one-point lead with 11 seconds remaining when Sujeet found one final takedown. The two points put him ahead 10-9 and completed one of the most dramatic comebacks of the Games.

The gold was India's first

in wrestling at the Asian Games since 2018 and made Sujeet only the third Indian to win the men's 65kg freestyle title, after Olympic medallists Yogeshwar Dutt in 2014 and Bajrang Punia in 2018.

Sujeet had moved the Delhi High Court seeking a trial in the 65kg category for the 2022 Asian Games, which were eventually held in 2023. The ad-hoc committee running Indian wrestling after the Wrestling Federation of India was de-recognised by the sports ministry had instead given Bajrang Punia a direct entry into the team.

Sujeet, along with women's wrestler Antim Panghal, challenged the decision in court. Antim eventually made the team and won bronze, while Vinesh Phogat was given direct entry in the 53kg category without trials. Sujeet, however, received no relief from the court.

India end 40-year wait for Asian Games women's hockey gold

STATESMAN NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi, 2 October

For a while, the Indian women's hockey team had been caught in a cycle of inconsistency, with injuries, a poor Pro League campaign that ended in relegation and a tendency to falter when the stakes were highest. They entered the Asian Games after finishing fifth at the World Cup, but put those setbacks behind them in emphatic fashion, ending a four-decade wait for the Asian Games gold with a 1-0 victory over defending champions China in the final on Friday.

For No. 8-ranked India, Lalremsiami Hmarzote's superb reverse-stick strike in the 10th minute proved enough to settle the contest, but the gold was secured by a defence that refused to yield and goalkeeper Bichu Devi, who stood tall whenever China threatened.

The defending champions dominated possession for long periods and threw wave after wave of attacks at the Indian circle, but India absorbed the pressure with remarkable discipline. Their defenders repeatedly put their bodies on the line, while Bichu Devi produced a crucial penalty-stroke save to keep China from drawing level.

The victory delivered two long-awaited prizes for India — their first Asian Games women's hockey gold since 1982 and direct qualification for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, a key target for coach Sjoerd Marijne since taking charge for a second



time in January this year. After 1982, India came close to reclaiming the crown twice, finishing runners-up in 1998 and 2018, but lost to South Korea and Japan respectively.

China, the Paris Olympics silver medallists, had to settle for silver, while Japan claimed bronze after beating South Korea 4-2 in a shoot-out in the third-place play-off.

Sakshi Rana found Lalremsiami with a well-weighted pass into the circle in the 10th minute. The forward took the ball in her stride before unleashing a fierce reverse-stick hit that flew into the upper netting, leaving the Chinese goalkeeper with no chance.

India held their shape and survived the final onslaught. When the final whistle sounded, four decades of waiting were over. India had their Asian Games women's hockey gold back, and more importantly, a direct route to the Los Angeles Olympics to go with it.

Blue Tigers up against the Selecao in landmark evening for Indian soccer

SIRSHENDU PANTH
Kolkata, 2 October

In an outing that is bound to remain etched in the folklore of Indian soccer irrespective of the result, the men's senior team is all set to take on the might of Brazil, easily the most popular side in this part of the world, here on Saturday.

India go into their Yuva Bharati Krirangan (Salt Lake Stadium) clash with the South American giants knowing pretty well just how wide the gap is on paper. Brazil are fifth in the latest FIFA men's ranking, while India are 138th — a difference of 133 places.

Brazil are five-time World Cup champions; India have never made the cut for the

mega soccer event. In fact, the Indian senior side have never confronted such a higher-ranked opponent.

But football has never really been a dry statistical affair, and the Blue Tigers will hope to continue their momentum after the highly impressive 1-1 draw on 25 September in Bengaluru with 44th-ranked Panama, a side which featured in the recent World Cup.

India can also draw inspiration from their past. They finished fourth in the 1956 Melbourne Olympics, clinched the gold at the Asian Games twice — New Delhi in 1951 and Jakarta in 1962, besides bagging a bronze in the 1970 Bangkok Asiad. But all these successes came in the

distant past. History, civilisation and soccer have moved apace. Soccer has undergone metamorphosis in technique, technicalities and tactics. In parallel, the national side's performance has continued to dip.

India's highest FIFA ranking was 94th, reached in 1996, while the team now stand 138th — a drop of 44 places in 30 years. The senior side lost to Jamaica and Zimbabwe in the Unity Cup, exited in round two of World Cup qualification and failed to reach the main round of the 2027 Asian Cup.

In such a grim scenario, the Panama match has come like a breath of fresh air.

Aussie



Brazil players during a training session ahead of their FIFA international friendly against India at the Vivekananda Yuva Bharati Krirangan in Kolkata. BISWAJIT GHOSHAL

international-turned Indian team member Ryan Williams was the fulcrum of the side's impressive show against Panama, as he found the target in the 41st minute from an Akash Mishra assist. Williams will need to again show his calibre of making the most of limited

opportunities Saturday, backed up by Manvir Singh's running ability and Ashique Kununiyan's pace and flank play to stretch the Brazilian defence, whenever India win the ball.

However, that is easier said than done against an opponent that belongs to a

different class.

The Selecao, coached by the redoubtable Carlo Ancelotti, arrive here after a 4-2 win over Australia. The first friendly between the two sides had ended in a draw.

The talismanic Vinicius Junior poses the biggest challenge to India's rearguard.

The Real Madrid forward — fleet-footed and crafty — is adept at testing the full backs one moment, and utilising the gaps between full-back and centre-back in the wink of a second. Akash Mishra, likely to start on India's right, will need midfield assistance to contain Vinicius, who can never be allowed to operate freely.

Defenders Anwar Ali and Bijoy Varghese will have their task cut out, with Brazil's forwards capable of dropping deep, switching positions and pouncing on spaces that appear when chased by a rearguard.

Brazil, though, will miss the flank play of the injured Raphinha, which could put more load on Vinicius and the young Endrick. Vinicius's clubmate tends to pick on spaces around the centre-backs and set out on dangerous runs. To counter such thrusts, the Indian defence needs to be a picture of discipline and caution.

In the midfield too, Lalengmawia Ralte, nicknamed Apuia, and Ricky Shabong, who played

stellar football against Panama, will have to showcase their ability to close down spaces, which may be tested heavily.

In such David versus Goliath battles, the weaker sides often tend to go too defensive. But Indian coach Khalid Jamil would perhaps do well to avoid that, as that would provide ample space and manoeuvrability to the Brazilian medios to lurk around the Indian penalty box and cause havoc. However, during the brief 15 minutes of open practice during the day, the Indians laid stress on taking cracks at goal, which seems to be the right prescription in the given circumstances.

Kick-off time: 7-30 pm.

